Bureaucratic Turnover After Civil Service Rollbacks

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August 12, 2026

Abstract

Insulating civil servants from removal on partisan or ideological grounds is central to modern public administration. Yet, the federal government and many U.S. states have weakened civil service protections, possibly enabling politically motivated terminations. I test whether civil service rollbacks increase politicization using a 2001 Florida law that removed tenure protections from approximately 16,000 mid-level bureaucrats. Using personnel and voter registration records of over 170,000 state employees, I do not find that employees misaligned with the administration were more likely to depart. However, departures increased by 4.7 pp (124% relative to baseline mean) among unprotected employees in the Department of Education—which experienced a 178% increase in at-will employees due to the 2001 law and had a contentious relationship with then-Governor Jeb Bush—after a 2003 reorganization increased gubernatorial control of the agency. Overall, my findings suggest that rollbacks can facilitate the politicization of increasingly polarized administrative states.

Keywords: Bureaucracy, state politics, civil service protections, agency politicization

Wordcount: 8,384

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Insulating civil servants from political influence is a fundamental tenet of modern public administration. Leading scholars in the early study of public bureaucracies argued for separating political decision-making and policy implementation. While agency tasks ought to be set by senior, democratically accountable officials, proponents argued, effectively providing public goods requires staffing the government with a cadre of employees managed according to their abilities, rather than their partisan affiliations (Wilson 1887; Kaufman 1956; Goodnow 2021). Modern research lends some support to these claims: with protections in place and employees insulated from political cycles, motivated employees join the civil service and develop crucial skills and expertise, leading to improved government performance (Gibbs 2020; Gailmard and Patty 2007; 2012; Aneja and Xu 2024; Lewis 2007; Oliveira et al. 2024, cf. Moreira and Pérez 2021).

In stark contrast to this vision of public administration, bureaucrats' job security is increasingly precarious in the United States. At the federal level, executive orders issued by President Trump are turning career civil servants with policy-relevant roles into "at-will" employees who can be efficiently dismissed without due process or appeal (Trump 2025). Similar, often even more extreme, rollbacks of civil service protections have occurred in many U.S. states. Over the last three decades, over twenty states, including Florida, Georgia, Kansas, Indiana, Missouri, Oklahoma, Mississippi, Arizona, and West Virginia have made it easier to fire public employees (Forman 2021; Stephenson 2012; Cournoyer 2012; Parson 2018; Spencer 2026). While the details vary, the state and federal reforms all share a common emphasis on reducing the burdens faced by managers looking to discipline or remove employees.

Weakening civil service protections aids managers trying to remove poorly performing employees from the workforce, but does it also open the door for increased politicization of previously insulated segments of the bureaucracy? Despite the spread of at-will employment in the public sector, there are relatively few answers. Researchers have examined the theoretical implications of civil service reform (Gibbs 2020; Ujhelyi 2014) and documented state employees' attitudes toward removing tenure protections (Coggburn 2006; Goodman and French 2011; Bowman et al. 2003; Battaglio 2010; Nigro and Kellough 2000; Bowman and West 2006), but no studies have used observational data to examine the effects of reclassifying employees to at-will status. I take on that task here, examining whether, as critics of civil service rollbacks contend, weakening civil service protections assists executives in removing political opponents from the

public sector (e.g., Piper, n.d.).

I argue that executives will be hesitant to remove employees solely due to opposing ideological views or partisan affiliations. Formerly protected employees possess unique expertise that is difficult to replace, Supreme Court cases have limited governments' ability to implement contemporary "spoils systems," and many agency tasks are performed similarly by liberals and conservatives. However, misaligned political views can lead to conflict between bureaucrats and the executive over the course of action an agency should take. With civil service protections removed, failures to implement aligned policy can be more swiftly met with disciplinary action, including termination. No longer facing the prospect of due process procedures or lengthy appeals processes, executives and agency heads are freer to remove employees viewed as unable or unwilling to implement policy priorities. Consequently, I argue, the removal of civil service protections increases the likelihood that conflict between misaligned bureaucrats and executives over policy will lead to dismissals from the workforce.

I test these expectations using the case of civil service reform in Florida. In 2001, Governor Jeb Bush signed into law "Service First," a package of personnel policies affecting how the state hired, fired, and compensated employees. Among other changes to personnel management, Service First transferred over 16,000 managerial, supervisory, and confidential positions out of the state's protected Career Service into the at-will Selected Exempt Service (SES). Beginning in July 2001, affected employees—many of them among the most experienced and well-compensated civil servants in the state workforce—could be removed from their positions for any otherwise legal reason without the right to appeal their termination.

I use personnel records, retrieved via public records requests, to examine how the removal of tenure protections under Service First affected employee departures. The data, which consist of monthly snapshots of nearly all Florida state employees from January 2000 through February 2004, are a rich source of information, including employees' full names, agencies, position codes, salaries, race, sex, civil service statuses and counties of employment. I also impute unique employee identification codes that allow me to track individuals' entry into and exit from the workforce. In total, the data cover 171,232 unique employees and 5,374,555 employee-month observations across 32 state agencies.

Pairing the personnel data with voter registration records, I test whether Service First, passed by a

Republican-controlled legislature and championed by a Republican governor, led to increased departures among more Democratic sectors of the workforce. Using a difference-in-differences design, I do not find that positions with more Democratic employees experienced heightened turnover after the weakening of civil service protections. In fact, I find little evidence of any increase in departure rates in sectors of the workforce more exposed to the weakening of civil service protections following the implementation of Service First.

Nevertheless, I demonstrate that when misalignment between bureaucrats and the executive manifests as conflict over policy, civil service rollbacks facilitate purges of opposing public sector employees. I take advantage of a 1998 constitutional referendum that gave the Florida Governor greater control over the Departments of State and Education in January 2003, roughly eighteen months after the onset of Service First. Reforming education policy was a cornerstone of Governor Bush's policy agenda and he had a contentious relationship with the state Department of Education, having called for its abolishment in his unsuccessful first run for governor. Service First expanded the number of Department of Education employees working at-will by 178% and in the quarter following Bush formally gaining control of the agency departures among SES employees increased by 4.7 percentage points—a 124% increase relative to the baseline mean of departing from the agency. Via a placebo test, I show that—despite Service First increasing the number of SES employees in the Department of State by 355% from 40 to 182—unprotected SES employees in the Department of State were no more likely to depart following reorganization, underscoring that the departures were isolated to the more polarizing Department of Education.

These results have important implications for the study of public bureaucracies and ongoing debates over the merits of weakening civil service protections. The rollback of civil service protections does not simply lead to a return to a pre-merit "regime of clerkship" (Carpenter 2001). Even without protections in place, modern executives face numerous barriers to removing employees that pre-merit presidents and governors did not face. Yet, in the context of modern governance, where controlling the bureaucracy is a paramount concern for executives trying to change policy, weakening civil service protections opens the door for more politicized personnel management. As the case of the Florida Department of Education highlights, when conflict erupts between misaligned bureaucrats and the executive, weakened civil service

protections allow the latter to more easily remove the former from the workforce. This finding has ramifications for the current rollbacks of some federal civil servants' tenure protections. In a polarized federal executive branch rife with conflict, weakened civil service protections will likely allow the president to remove misaligned employees viewed as standing in the way of implementing policy goals. While this can foster increased accountability of important policymaking positions, it can also lead to potentially concerning decreases in bureaucratic expertise and capacity (Richardson 2019).

The Rise and Retrenchment of Civil Service Protections

The introduction of merit-based hiring in public bureaucracies in the late 19th Century and early-to-mid 20th Century improved the quality of employees, reduced turnover, and, in some cases, enhanced service delivery (Aneja and Xu 2024; Moreira and Pérez 2021).[1] The associated rise of tenure protections also led to improvements in the quality of the public sector workforce. As Gailmard and Patty (2007, 2012) demonstrate, job protections are key for developing a skilled bureaucracy. Individuals who are interested in working for the government face a dilemma when considering public service. Government jobs often require learning the intricacies of rules, procedures, and policies that, while necessary for government work, are not always useful in other fields. If bureaucrats know that they can be promptly removed for political reasons, they will be hesitant to invest in acquiring the know-how to effectively do their jobs. Protecting employees from hasty or politically motivated dismissals reduces the risk of investing in the expertise necessary for skilled administration. With protections in place, bureaucrats interested in shaping public policy stick around and get better at their jobs, creating a skilled, albeit not neutral, workforce.

At the same time, however, tenure protections can prove frustrating to executives and managers dealing with the legal and logistical costs of punishing poorly performing employees. Civil service protections help

[1]Compared to the federal government, the U.S. states were relatively late to adopt merit-based protections for government employees. Although Massachusetts and New York implemented merit-based civil service systems in the 1880s, only seven other states had passed civil service laws by 1936 (Folke, Hirano, and Snyder 2011). In 1939, the federal government required that state employees working in agencies receiving federal block grants via the Social Security program enjoy merit-based protections. Despite this requirement, many states were still slow to implement broad-based civil service systems. Eighteen states did not implement a workforce-wide civil service system until after 1960, while Texas has never passed a broad civil service law for its public workforce (Walters 2002).

incentivize skilled employees to join the workforce, but too much insulation can protect unmotivated employees (Gibbs 2020). In the 1990s, a number of U.S. states began to target employees' protections, arguing that they stood in the way of quality administration. In Georgia, Governor Zell Miller told the legislature in 1996 that the state's merit system "offers no reward for good workers. It only provides cover for bad workers" (Walters 2002). Heeding the governor's call for reform, the state passed legislation mandating that, beginning in July 1996, all new hires in the Georgia state workforce would serve at-will. Affected employees could be fired for any otherwise legal reason without recourse to due process or appeal. Florida followed suit five years later, removing protections for a wide swath of mid-level managers and supervisors. Since then, a number of other states, largely under Republican control, have also made it easier to fire state employees (McGrath 2013). Indiana and Arizona increased the share of their public sectors serving at-will in 2011 and 2012, respectively (Stephenson 2012; Cournoyer 2012). Kansas followed suit in 2015 and recent legislation in Missouri, West Virginia, and Oklahoma have turned many state employees into at-will workers (Forman 2021; Parson 2018; Lorenz 2019; Spencer 2026). In a unique case, Mississippi has periodically revoked tenure protections for specific agencies following significant scandals or policy failures (*PEER Report 670* 2022; *PEER Report 651* 2020). In total, approximately twenty states have implemented significant reforms to their civil service systems since the 1990s (Glock and Mukherjee 2025).

More recently, President Trump has targeted the protections of senior federal employees. At the end of his first term, Trump created Schedule F, a new unprotected category in the federal personnel system. Via executive order, he directed agencies to identify employees in "positions of a confidential, policy-determining, policy-making, or policy-advocating character" for reclassification as at-will employees (Trump 2020). Although Schedule F was overturned by President Biden upon taking office and never implemented, Trump issued a similar order at the beginning of his second term, creating a new at-will Schedule Policy/Career similar to Schedule F. The Office of Personnel Management has estimated that approximately 50,000 senior civil servants will be moved into this new category (Office of Personnel Management 2026).

Theoretical studies suggest some potential implications of civil service rollbacks. Gibbs (2020) shows that civil service protections incentivize motivated bureaucrats to enter and remain in the workforce be-

cause they do not have to work as hard to differentiate themselves from their unmotivated peers. As managers gain more power to remove bureaucrats, unmotivated employees become easier to remove. Yet, removing tenure protections altogether pushes motivated employees to seek employment elsewhere, despite their interest in government work. Rolling back protections can have political implications too, potentially affecting both bureaucrats' willingness to work against opposing principals' reelection and politicians' incentives to use the workforce for partisan goals (Forand 2019; Ujhelyi 2014).

Surveys of state employees and managers affected by civil service rollbacks provide a mixed picture of state-level rollbacks. Personnel officials have a generally positive view toward at-will employment, especially as it pertains to increasing the responsiveness of employees (Coggburn 2006; Goodman and French 2011; Kim and Kellough 2014), although others report decreased motivation and trust after reform (Battaglio and Condrey 2009; Battaglio 2010). Affected employees who lost their tenure protections see fewer benefits (Bowman and West 2006; Nigro and Kellough 2000; Bowman et al. 2003). While relatively few employees report that at-will employment contributes to politically motivated management, employees in multiple states note that removing tenure protections facilitate budget cuts and government downsizing initiatives (Bowman et al. 2003; Goodman and French 2011; Coggburn 2006).

These surveys provide a helpful overview of the views of employees affected by state-level civil service rollbacks, but they are imperfect tests of the effects of weakening protections. For one, they lack control groups of employees who retained their protections and data from before rollbacks occurred. As a result, it is difficult to parse whether the surveys' results are due to the weakening of protections or some other factor. Likewise, since a key concern with the rollback of civil service protections is the possibility of increased terminations of opposing employees, surveying remaining employees potentially introduces bias. If reforms led to heightened turnover immediately following the policy change, then not including those departed employees in a survey sample provides an overly optimistic view of the consequences of civil service rollbacks. What is needed, in order to properly test the effects of civil service rollbacks, is observational data from both before and after a rollback of civil service protections that only affected a segment of the public sector. Testing whether the rollback led to increased terminations of opposing employees also requires measures of the alignment between civil servants and the executive.

Public Sector Turnover Following the Rollback of Protections

Executives—presidents and governors—build a case for reelection and burnish their legacies by following through on policy promises (Moe 1985). In part, this requires working with the legislature to pass new laws. Increasingly, however, given the importance and ubiquity of administrative rulemaking, controlling the bureaucracy is crucial for implementing policy goals. This is a well known presidential strategy, but is also applies to governors. Much like their federal counterparts, state agencies have taken on increasing policymaking responsibilities over the 20th Century (Jenks and Wright 1993). Today, state agencies are loci of policymaking capacity and expertise, especially in the numerous states with part-time civilian legislatures (Boushey and McGrath 2017). Consequently, governors, much like presidents, need to control state agencies in order to implement their preferred policies.

Personnel are a key means for controlling agencies. Presidents and governors "politicize" opposing agencies by staffing them with appointees committed to the executive's policy goals (Lewis 2008; Hollibaugh and Rothenberg 2024; Moe 1985; Moore 2018; Yackee 2025). These appointees, often located in positions of power within agency hierarchies, offer executives the chance to place loyal, responsive agents in agencies that disagree with the administration. While politicization comes at the risk of marginalizing experienced career employees, it offers presidents and governors a direct tool for bringing agencies in line. Other work has shown that similar tactics are employed further down agencies' organizational charts. Presidents, for instance, allocate more personnel resources to agencies that are more aligned with administration goals and strategically unionize aligned employees to insulate them from interference by future opposing presidents (Bolton 2021; Chen and Johnson 2014). Some studies have also found higher turnover of misaligned senior civil servants following the election of a new president (Doherty, Lewis, and Limbocker 2019a, 2019b). However, it is difficult to parse whether these departures are voluntary or involuntary and studies of the entire federal workforce during presidential transitions suggest that heightened turnover is not widespread (Bolton, de Figueiredo, and Lewis 2021; Spenkuch, Teso, and Xu 2023).

The rollback of civil service protections ostensibly opens the door to further politicization. With tenure protections removed, the costs of dismissing employees decrease. Employees no longer enjoy the

right to respond to their notice of demotion or termination and lack the opportunity to appeal their dismissal. As a result, opposing civil servants can be dismissed quickly much like political appointees, providing presidents and governors with more opportunities to remove opposing employees and add supporters.

Yet, despite the ease with which formerly protected employees can be dismissed from their positions, executives still face barriers to removing misaligned employees. For one, dismissing employees imposes costs on an administration. Unlike public sector employees working before the implementation of merit-based civil service systems, contemporary employees have not served in a "regime of clerkship" where there is little need or incentive to invest in learning the intricacies of public administration (Carpenter 2001). Today, civil servants work in positions with influence over critical policy, budgetary, and regulatory decisions, honing their skills over time (Heclo 1977; Doherty, Lewis, and Limbocker 2019a). As a result, finding replacements who can perform the necessary tasks is a challenge. Even if the executive does not intend to replace fired employees, the president or governor still has to contend with the possibility of extended vacancies, which can lead to consequential policy failures visible to voters (Lewis 2011; Piper and Lewis 2023).

Supreme Court decisions have also placed limits on the degree to which at-will employees can be removed for political reasons. In 1976 in *Elrod v. Burns*, the Supreme Court restricted, on First Amendment grounds, governments' ability to remove employees in non-policymaking roles due to their partisan affiliation. While administrations can use partisanship and political loyalty as criteria for staffing positions that influence policy, lower-level positions cannot be staffed according to political views. In 1980, the Supreme Court decision in *Branti v. Finkel* further refined which positions can be staffed according to political considerations, finding that it is up to the government to show that "party affiliation is an appropriate requirement for the effective performance of the public office involved." These cases limit the extent to which civil service rollbacks can facilitate a return to a spoils system. Executives can use political criteria to remove formerly protected employees in policy-relevant roles, but they invite court sanction by using partisanship and ideology to manage wider swaths of the public sector.

A final barrier to removing misaligned employees after the weakening of civil service protections is that, in many cases, employees' ideology and partisanship have little influence on how they do their jobs.

Much of what public bureaucracies do is not subject to much attention, much less partisan conflict over the proper course of action (Richardson 2024). This is true at the federal level, but it is especially the case in the states, where public agencies are subject to considerably less media scrutiny than their federal counterparts. The lack of attention combined with the fact that there is not a liberal or Democratic way to inspect bridges, oversee highway transportation programs, deliver the mail, forecast the weather, or accomplish numerous other types of bureaucratic tasks means that there is little reason for executives to care whether many government employees share their political views. The job is done the same regardless of the political views of who does it. Misalignment, in other words, is insufficient grounds for an executive to want to remove a bureaucrat.

Executives are unlikely to use civil service rollbacks to remove misaligned employees simply because they possess different political views, but the weakening of protections allows cases of actual conflict to be more easily punished. While governments perform tasks that are not subject to conflict, they also write environmental regulations, deport undocumented immigrants, and enforce anti-trust laws — tasks subject to considerable political disagreement. In these areas, where misalignment can have ramifications for important policy outcomes, the rollback of protections provides an additional tool for executives looking to exert control. With protections removed, cases where misalignment leads to actual conflict over policy can be more easily punished. Before the rollback of protections, executives faced legal and logistical roadblocks to punishing employees viewed as standing in the way of achieving policy goals. With bureaucrats serving at-will, these barriers have been removed, meaning that instances of disagreement over policy will more likely lead to more disciplinary actions including, but not limited to, terminations. Thus, with protections removed, turnover will likely increase when there exists a high degree of conflict between bureaucrats and the executive.

The Case of Service First

I test these expectations using the case of Florida's 2001 civil service reform. Before reform, most state of Florida employees were classified in the Career Service. Disciplining these employees required establish-

ing "cause." According to contemporary statutory language, "Cause shall include, but not be limited to, negligence, inefficiency or inability to perform assigned duties, insubordination, willful violation of the provisions of law or agency rules, conduct unbecoming a public employee, misconduct, habitual drug abuse, or conviction of any crime involving moral turpitude" (Florida Legislature 2000). Agencies had leeway to add additional language, such as excessive absenteeism, to their own definitions of cause (Gertz 2001). If an employee's supervisors determined that an employee's action constituted cause for discipline, the employee would be notified in writing of the penalty and offered an opportunity to resign or refute the allegations. If the supervisors decided to continue with the discipline, the employee was informed via a final action letter and could appeal to the state's Public Employees Relations Commission (PERC), consisting of three gubernatorial appointees serving four-year terms.

The evidence on the costs imposed on supervisors interested in disciplining employees under the pre-reform system is limited and mixed. Gertz (2001) shows that the appeals process was not particularly difficult for supervisors and agencies. In the years leading up to reform in 2001, approximately one-third of employees who were dismissed or suspended appealed their discipline. Of those who did appeal, a majority of punishments were upheld. In fiscal year 1999, for instance, only 6% of appeals heard by PERC were reversed or mitigated. Nevertheless, despite the infrequency of appeals and agencies' punishments being overturned, many critics found the state's civil service systems to be burdensome and inefficient (West and Bowman 2004).

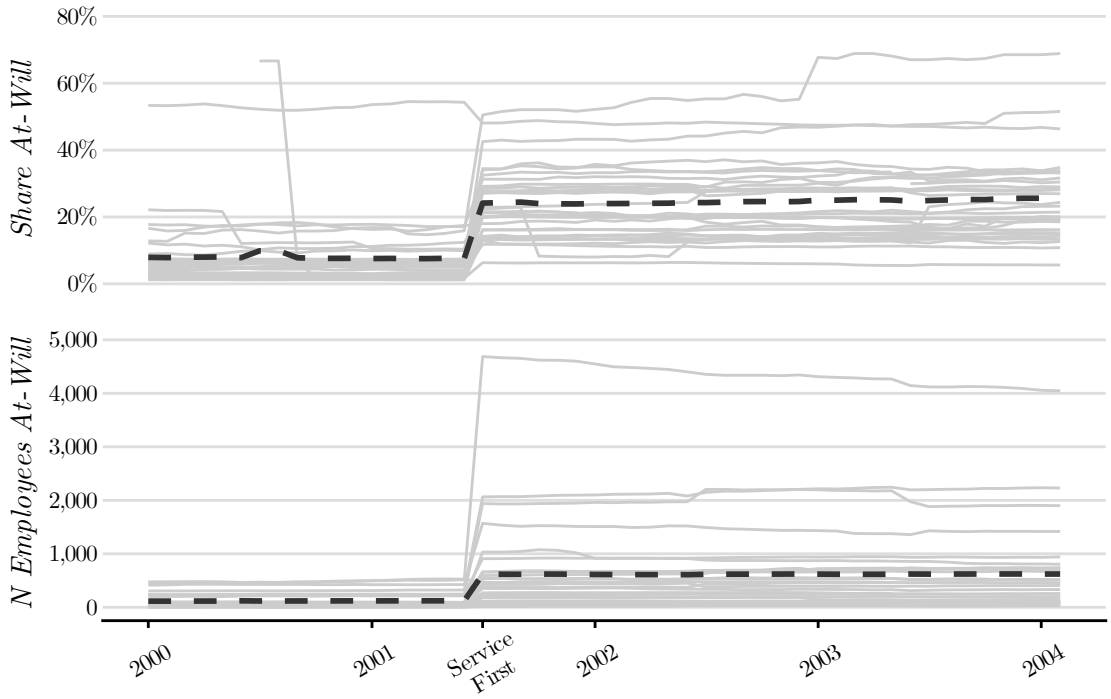
In his 2001 State of the State address, Governor Jeb Bush called for the adoption of "Service First," a major reform of Florida's civil service system. Alluding to the private sector management principles that inspired the reforms, he told the legislature that "now it is time to reform our employment system so that, like the world-class service organizations that are driving Florida's economy, state government can provide the effective and efficient service that its 16 million citizens rightfully expect." The legislature heeded his call and promptly passed the package of reforms in May 2001.

Service First took effect in July 2001 and instituted numerous changes to Florida's civil service system. Streamlined hiring procedures reduced the amount of paperwork managers had to complete to hire new candidates. The state's 3,300 position classifications were collapsed to 145 occupational groups, allowing

managers to grant salary raises without changing employees' position titles. Seniority-based "bumping" during reductions in force was eliminated and "poor performance" was added as cause for disciplining or removing career employees (Bowman et al. 2003; *State of Florida Annual Workforce Report: January through December, 2001,* n.d.). The most significant feature of the reform, however, was the reclassification of approximately 16,000 mid-level employees in confidential, managerial, and supervisory positions from the state's Career Service to the at-will SES. Affected employees received additional paid time off and improved benefits but lost their tenure protections (West and Bowman 2004). Employees in supervisory, managerial, and confidential positions could now be dismissed from their roles for any otherwise legal reason, with no due process rights or options for appeal.

The reform removed civil service protections for many experienced, highly-paid civil servants in the Florida bureaucracy. Using personnel data described in the next section, I show in Figure A.1 in the SI that the probability of being switched from the Career Service to the SES in July 2001 was close to zero for the lowest-paid full-time employees in the Florida workforce. In contrast, the predicted probability of losing civil service protections due to Service First exceeded 0.5 for the highest-paid civil servants working in or around the capital of Tallahassee. The probability of losing civil service protections also increased with years of experience working for the state, underscoring that the reform affected senior bureaucrats within the state workforce.

Figure 1 – The Size of the At-Will SES Dramatically Increased in July 2001. Shows the share and number of full-time Florida state employees in the SES in each agency from January 2000 through February 2004 by month. The black dashed lines show, respectively, the mean share and number of SES employees. Values calculated from state personnel data described in detail below.



Prior to Service First, most employees in Florida's executive branch fell into one of three personnel groups: the Career Service, the SES, or the Senior Management Service.[2] The vast majority of employees served in the Career Service, while agency leaders and high-level political appointees were covered by the SES and Senior Management Service, respectively. As shown in Figure 1, which displays the share and number of full-time SES employees across 32 Florida state agencies (black dashed lines denote mean values), the SES constituted a small part of the workforce before July 2001. Before the onset of Service First, the average agency had about 122 SES employees or 8% of an agency's total full-time workforce. After July 2001, the mean share of SES employees in an agency jumped to 24%. The average agency now employed

[2]Overall, 99% of Florida state employees in the period 2000-2004 were employed in either the Career Service or the SES. In an average month, approximately 506 people worked in the Senior Management Service. Given its small and relatively static size over the study period, it is excluded from calculations. Likewise, I also exclude the small number of employees working outside of the Career Service, SES, and Senior Management Service. These include a small number of elected and appointed officials as well as some other exempt and contracted employees.

approximately 620 SES employees. Statewide, over 17% of the workforce—over 18,500 employees— served in the SES following Service First. Some agencies were particularly affected by the reform efforts due to the share of their workforce employed in mid-level positions. The share of the Department of Management Services serving in the SES, for instance, increased from around 5% to 42% in July 2001, while the share of SES employees in the Department of Corrections only increased by five percentage points.

Evidence

I primarily rely on employee personnel data, collected via public records requests to the Florida Department of Management Services, to test how Service First affected employee turnover. The data consist of monthly snapshots of employees in Florida's State Personnel System from January 2000 through February 2004.[3] Nearly all employees of the Florida Executive Branch are included in the snapshots.[4] The data include 171,232 unique employees and 5,374,555 employee-month observations. The snapshots provide a rich description of public employees in Florida, containing, among other variables, employees' full name, agency, bureau, civil service status, county of employment, race, sex, initial hire date, full-time status, and annual salary. I impute unique employee identification codes that follow employees over time by grouping observations with similar observable characteristics across months. If a set of observations share the same first and last names, middle initials, race, sex, and initial hire dates, I deem it to be the same person.[5]

The personnel files do not provide a deterministic mapping of whether an employee in the Career Service before July 2001 will be reclassified into the SES due to Service First. In other words, it is only possible to observe who receives the treatment once treatment occurs. According to the state, being reclassified in July 2001 was a function of an employee's Collective Bargaining Unit (CBU) and position code,

[3]The data do not extend past February 2004 due to a large spike in missing values for variables like initial hire data, race, and middle initial that make it difficult to group together similar monthly observations and assign them to be the same unique employee. The abrupt change is likely due to the state's rollout of its People First initiative that privatized much of the state's human resources organization.

[4]The data include employees in the State Personnel System, which excludes state university and Florida Lottery employees.

[5]In a small number of cases, the data include more than one observation that have the same first and last names, middle initials, race, sex, and initial hire date, but different annual salaries. In those cases, I drop the observation with the lower listed salary.

both of which are provided in the monthly personnel snapshots. CBU designations, which are created by PERC, group together employees performing similar types of work based on their collective bargaining status. Most employees who lost their protections served in either the Managerial/Confidential or Supervisory CBUs, neither of which can collectively bargain.[6] Regardless of their CBU designation, employees working in dangerous positions, administrative law judges, hearing officers, and health care workers were exempt from reclassification and remained in the Career Service (*Effect of Changes Due to Senate Bill 466*). In practice, however, either due to additional criteria or insufficient data, the given guidelines for being switched from the Career Service into the SES do not materialize in the personnel data. In the personnel data received from the state, some employees in other CBUs were switched out of the Career Service into the SES while employees who ostensibly should have been reclassified remained in the Career Service.

I mitigate this issue by aggregating the data to the position level for analysis.[7] Despite the lack of a deterministic mapping, employees' treatment status correlates with observable pre-treatment covariates. Figure 2 shows the distribution of the share of employees in a given position that were switched into the SES under Service First. Most positions had few if any employees switched, while a smaller number of positions with fewer employees were nearly entirely reclassified from the Career Service into the SES.[8] As a result of this distribution, it is possible to aggregate the individual-level data and test whether segments of the workforce where most employees were switched to at-will status under Service First experienced greater turnover in the wake of the policy change.[9] This approach resembles the approach taken in recent

[6] The state defines Supervisory employees as those who "spend the majority of their time communicating with, motivating, training and evaluating employees, and planning and directing employees' work. Supervisory employees have the authority to hire, transfer, suspend, layoff, recall, promote, discharge, assign, reward or discipline subordinate employees or to effectively recommend such actions." Managerial/Confidential employees "are involved in collective bargaining, personnel or budget administration...[or] act in a confidential capacity to assist or aid managerial employees" (DMS, n.d.).

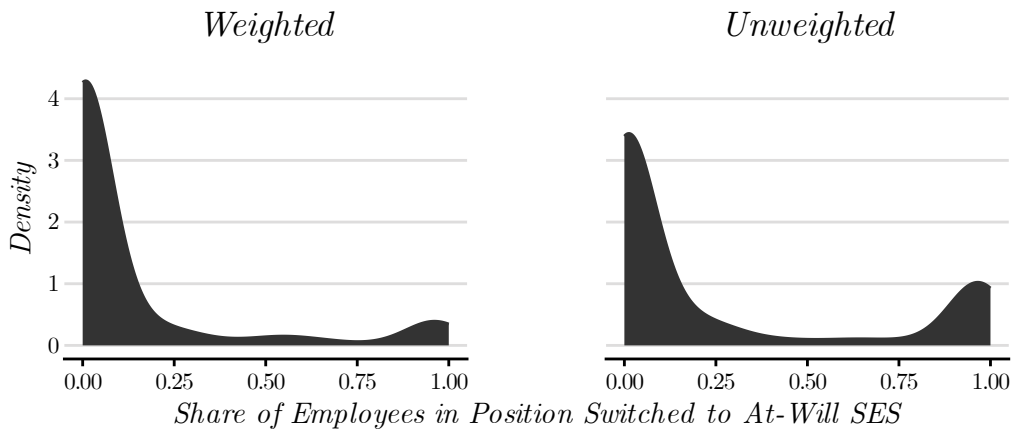
[7] Positions with 20 or fewer employees before the onset of Service First are removed from the analysis to improve stability.

[8] The R^2 of regressing whether an employee was actually switched from the career service to the SES in July 2001 on position is 0.73. Including employees' CBU codes as a covariate does not increase the R^2. A more fully-specified linear model that regresses whether an employee was switched on race, gender, earnings, years of experience, location, agency, and position has an R^2 of 0.74.

[9] There were 2,668 unique positions in the workforce immediately before the onset of Service First. Part of the reform efforts involved changing the position codes. As such, the unit of analysis is the pre-treatment position code. Only employees who began their employment spells before Service First are included in the analysis. See Figure E.6 for the number of employees in each unit before and after Service First. Unfortunately, the state was unable to

research analyzing the impacts of government shutdowns using the share of furloughed employees in an agency or bureau (Resh et al. 2025; Herpfer, Maturana, and Teodorescu 2025).

Figure 2 – Distribution of Treatment Intensity. Shows the distribution of the share of employees in a position being switched from the Career Service to the at-will SES. The left plot shows the distribution weighted by the number of employees within each position, while the right plot shows the unweighted distribution.



I measure misalignment with the Republican Bush administration by merging the personnel records with individual-level voter registration data from Florida. The voter data note the registered partisanship of all Florida voters as of May 2005. I match Florida state employees to their associated voter information using employees' first and last name, middle initial, race, sex, and county of employment. Section C in the SI provides additional details and diagnostics regarding the merge process. Overall, 57% of the state employees in the personnel file were matched to a voter, which largely aligns with the 66% overall citizen voter registration rate in Florida in November 2002 (U.S. Census Bureau 2004).

The Florida Division of Elections destroys copies of the voter file after one year. Obtaining historical voter registration records from over two decades ago is therefore no small feat, but the records are still capturing bureaucrats' registered partisanship nearly four years after Service First was implemented. As a result, the data excludes bureaucrats who moved out of state, passed away, or were dropped from the voter rolls. It also misidentifies employees who switched their partisan registration.

Nevertheless, these potential issues are likely of limited concern. As shown in Figure C.2 in the SI,

provide employees' position titles, only the codes associated with the positions.

Florida had a relatively low outmigration rate in 2001 compared to other states. As expected, match rates are lower for employees who depart the dataset (i.e., leave state employment) but the difference in match rates across those employees who remained and departed is no larger in border counties, suggesting that outmigration is not driving these gaps (See Table C.1). Moreover, the relatively short study period means that sizable attrition through death or deregistration is unlikely.[10] Some research demonstrates that bureaucrats change their partisan affiliations to align with their principals, but this largely applies to top-level agency heads and managers, not the mid-level employees I am most interested in here (Geys et al. 2024).

I use a difference-in-differences design to test whether Service First increased departures of misaligned employees. The dependent variable is the share of employees in a position that left the dataset, and therefore state employment, in a given quarter.[11] The data is thinned from monthly to quarterly snapshots to reduce noisy month-to-month fluctuations in departure rates.[12] Treatment is a binarized version of the share of employees in a position that were actually switched into the SES in July 2001 under Service First. Given some threshold value $\theta \in [0, 0.5]$, a position is deemed treated if the share of employees in the position switched into the SES in July 2001 is greater than or equal to $1 - \theta$. Likewise, a position is a control unit if the share of switched employees is less than or equal to θ. To put it another way, most but not all employees in "treated" positions receive the treatment of being switched into the SES, but not everyone and vice versa. Stricter thresholds (e.g., $\theta = 0.01$) restrict the control (treatment) group to only those positions where the probability of a given employee being switched is less than or equal to 0.01 (greater than or equal to 0.99). Expanding the thresholds includes additional positions in the estimates, reducing variance at the cost of greater bias. Given the distribution of exposure to reclassification shown in Figure 2, I use $\theta = 0.1$ for the main results. However, as discussed in the following section, the results are robust to $\theta \in \{0.05, 0.25, 0.5\}$. Table E.1 provides descriptive statistics for positions in the treatment and control

[10] In order to be dropped from the voter registration rolls in Florida, someone must first be deemed inactive by the Department of State by not responding to address confirmation notices and then not participate in two general elections (Florida Legislature 2025).

[11] Figure E.1 shows the raw quarterly departure rates for the main treatment and control groups, which are defined below.

[12] Validation checks with aggregated separation data received directly from a state agency suggests that measuring departures as the last month an employee appears in the data is imprecise. See Section B in the SI for further discussion.

groups under various definitions of θ and Figure E.4 shows the most common agencies in the treatment and control groups.

I use the `PanelMatch R` Package to estimate the effect of Service First on position-level departure rates (Kim et al. 2022). Implementing methods developed in Imai, Kim, and Wang (2023) and Rauh, Kim, and Imai (2025), `PanelMatch` provides methods for estimating difference-in-differences models with more than two time periods, heterogeneous treatment effects, and a binary moderator variable. I utilize it here to estimate the Average Treatment Effect on the Treated (ATT) of a position being (mostly) reclassified into the at-will SES on position-level departure rates. Intuitively, the estimand is, at a given quarter after Service First, the difference between the departure rates of positions affected by Service First and those same positions in a counterfactual world in which Service First did not occur. The former set of values is observable, while the latter is not.

For each treated position affected by Service First, `PanelMatch` constructs a set of control positions to serve as the counterfactual. Since treatment only occurs once, nearly all control positions are included in each treated unit's control set. I use Covariate Balance Propensity Score weighting to balance the control sets on observable features of the positions (Imai and Ratkovic 2014). In particular, control sets are reweighted to match treated positions' mean salary, number of employees, share of employees who are white, share of employees who are male, employees' mean years of experience working with the state, and share of employees working in and around the capital of Tallahassee. Crucially, in order for `PanelMatch` to be a valid estimator, the parallel trends assumption that, in the absence of the rollback of protections, the difference in departure rates across treated and untreated positions remains constant needs to be satisfied. I provide suggestive evidence that is the case in Figure E.5, which plots the standardized differences between mean covariate values and the dependent variable for treated and control positions. All differences are below the conventional threshold of 0.2 by the time of Service First, suggesting that, leading up to July 2001, control sets are observationally similar to the treated positions affected by Service First (Normand et al. 2001; Austin 2011; Cohen 1977). This suggests that, at the time of Service First in July 2001, the treated positions and their weighted control positions would have followed a similar trajectory in a hypothetical world in which a rollback did not actually occur.

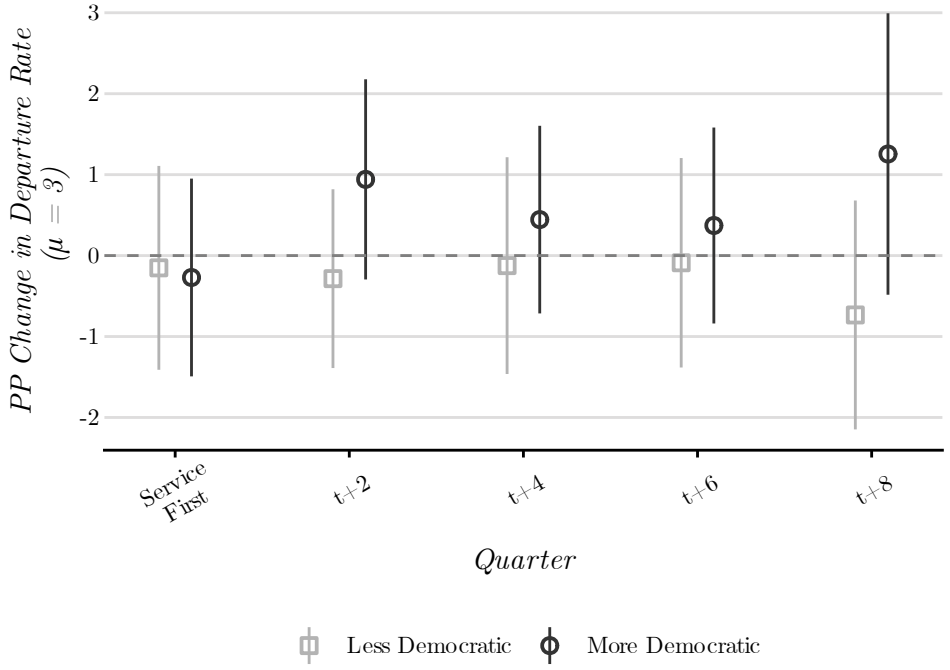
With treated and weighted control sets in hand, `PanelMatch` uses a difference-in-differences estimator to calculate the ATT conditional on partisanship. I calculate the effect of Service First separately for positions where the share of Democratic employees does and does not exceed the median Democratic share across all positions.[13] Within more- and less-Democratic positions, the difference-in-differences estimator is calculated, for a given quarter following Service First, as the change in the treated position's departure rate from the last pre-reform quarter to the given post-reform quarter minus the weighted average of the same change for positions in the control set. The average of those differences across, respectively, more- and less-Democratic treated positions is the estimator for a given quarter. Standard errors are estimated using a block bootstrap (N iterations = 5,000), permitting dependence within positions over time but assuming independence across positions.

Figure 3 displays the main results. The black circles (grey squares) show the estimated treatment effects of losing protections among positions comprised of more (less) registered Democrats. The point estimates show the percentage point change in the quarterly departure rate, estimated separately for more- and less-Democratic positions relative to their matched controls, at the time of Service First and two, four, six, and eight quarters later. For context, the baseline mean departure rate across the study period ($\mu = 3$) is shown on the vertical axis. Overall, the estimates suggest that, regardless of partisan alignment, there was little increase in turnover following the rollback of protections.[14] Positions comprised of more Democrats ostensibly saw higher turnover relative to positions comprised of fewer Democrats in some quarters, but there is no evidence that more misaligned positions experienced higher turnover relative to insulated positions in the control group.

[13] `PanelMatch` requires a binary moderating variable. I show in the SI that my findings are robust to an alternative definition of the moderator where a misaligned position's share of Democrats exceeds the third quartile instead of the median.

[14] Figure D.1 shows, using various values for the treatment threshold θ and no partisan moderation, that the rollback of protections under Service First led to little overall change in departure rates.

Figure 3 – Little Evidence of Increased Departures in More Democratic Positions. Shows point estimates and 95% confidence intervals of the effect of Service First on the share of employees who depart from a position in a given quarter, by the partisan composition of the position. Darker circles (Lighter squares) show the effect for positions where the share of democrats exceeds (is less than) the median across the study period. A position is deemed to be treated if 90% or more of the employees in the position were actually switched into the SES due to Service First. The control group includes all positions where fewer than 10% of the employees were switched. Figure D.2 shows results using different treatment thresholds. μ shows the respective baseline mean departure rates.



The results in Figure 3 are robust to alternative measurement strategies. Figure D.2 in the SI shows that similar results hold when using alternative definitions of which positions belong in the treated and control groups (i.e., different definitions of θ). Figure D.3 shows that the findings are also robust to an alternative definition of position misalignment where more-Democratic positions exceed the 75th percentile rather than the median across all positions. Likewise, Figures D.4 and D.5 show that similar findings hold when using the agency-position as the unit of analysis. While not as well-balanced in the pre-treatment periods (see Figure E.7), this design allows for the inclusion of agency-level exact matching, ensuring that treated positions are only compared to other positions within the same agency.[15]

[15]Among other benefits, constraining control sets to only include positions in the same agency removes unobserved variation across agencies in the influence of the governor versus independently elected agency heads (Seifter

Service First & The Florida Department of Education

There is little evidence that mid-level employees misaligned with the Bush administration were more likely to depart following Service First and the loss of job protections. Yet, as I argue above, ideological and partisan misalignment between bureaucrats and the executive does not necessarily translate into actual conflict. As a result, I now turn to examining the impacts of Service First on the Florida Department of Education, an agency that had an especially contentious relationship with Governor Bush and came under greater gubernatorial control eighteen months after Service First.

In 1998, Florida voters passed a constitutional amendment increasing the governor's power over the Executive Branch. The amendment restructured the relatively large Florida Cabinet, reducing its size from six to three members. In addition to folding the state Comptroller and Treasurer into a single position, the amendment removed the Secretary of State and Commissioner of Education from the Cabinet. Rather than being led by an elected official, the Department of State would now be led by an official appointed by the Governor. Likewise, the Commissioner of Education would be appointed by a new State Board of Education appointed by the Governor and confirmed by the Senate. The amendment, which came into effect at the beginning of Jeb Bush's second term in January 2003, effectively increased his control over both agencies.

The Department of Education was key to Bush's policy agenda. Education was a central issue of his successful 1998 campaign for governor. Touting his experience co-founding Florida's first public charter school, he advocated for increased testing, transparent school rankings, and providing vouchers to parents of students in poorly-performing schools (Johnston 1998). He also added the state's educational commissioner, Frank Brogan, to his ticket as candidate for lieutenant governor. As governor, he signed into law significant education reform in 1999 that incorporated many of the policy changes he advocated for during the campaign.

Bush also had an adversarial relationship with the Florida state employees tasked with implementing education policy. Although he moderated his position by the time he was inaugurated, he had called for

2017, 2018).

abolishing the Florida Department of Education during his unsuccessful 1994 campaign for governor, describing it as "a first step in restructuring how our schools' delivery of education works" (Navarro 1998; Mitchell and Van Gieson 1993). Years later, looking back on his time as governor while running for president, Bush summed up the general resistance he faced from public sector education employees at all levels of government:

> These reforms weren't always popular. We were fought every step of the way by status quo education bureaucrats. We spent huge amounts of time filling out paperwork for federal bureaucrats. And the teachers unions hated what we were doing. In my re-election campaign in 2002, they didn't just bankroll my opponent; they mortgaged their building to do it. But they lost, and the kids won (Bush 2015).

The Service First reforms provided Bush an opportunity to remove opposing Department of Education employees during the agency's 2003 reorganization. The number of SES employees in the Department of Education nearly tripled between June and July 2001. Before the onset of Service First, approximately 11% of the agency's workforce was in an SES position. After the reforms, 29% of the Department of Education served at-will in the SES. I test whether these unprotected employees were more likely to depart after Bush gained additional control of the agency in January 2003. Formula 1 summarizes my modeling strategy. Filtering the personnel data to only employees in the Department of Education, I regress whether employee i departs in quarter q against the interaction of a quarterly time fixed effect and a binary variable indicating whether the employee is part of the at-will SES. They key test is whether, in the quarter following Bush gaining control of the agency, departures are more likely among at-will SES employees. The matrix $\mathbf{Z}$ includes various controls, including whether an employee is white, female, and employed in or around Tallahassee. The matrix also includes the county unemployment rate and fixed effects for employees' years of experience. I fit the model using logistic regression and cluster standard errors by employee.

$$depart_{iq} = \alpha + quarter_q \times ses_i + \Phi \mathbf{Z}_{iq} + \epsilon_{iq} \tag{1}$$

As a placebo test, I also estimate Formula 1 using only employees in the Department of State. While

the Department of State was seemingly not subject to the same scrutiny or conflict as the Department of Education, it was affected by the rollback of civil service protections. After Service First, the share of the Department of State working in the SES increased from 6% to 28%. Therefore, despite the lack of apparent conflict between the agency and the governor, many employees in the Department of State were also made easier to remove due to Service First.

Figure 4 – At-Will Employees in Department of Education More Likely to Depart in Quarter After Reorganization. Shows the difference in the predicted probability of departing the workforce for employees in the at-will SES compared to the protected Career Service, by agency (i.e., Education and State). Bars denote 95% confidence intervals. Standard errors are clustered by employee. Predicted probabilities are calculated using observed values via the `marginaleffects R` package. Shading indicates the onset of the cabinet reorganization that gave Governor Jeb Bush greater control of the agency. μ shows the respective baseline mean departure rates.

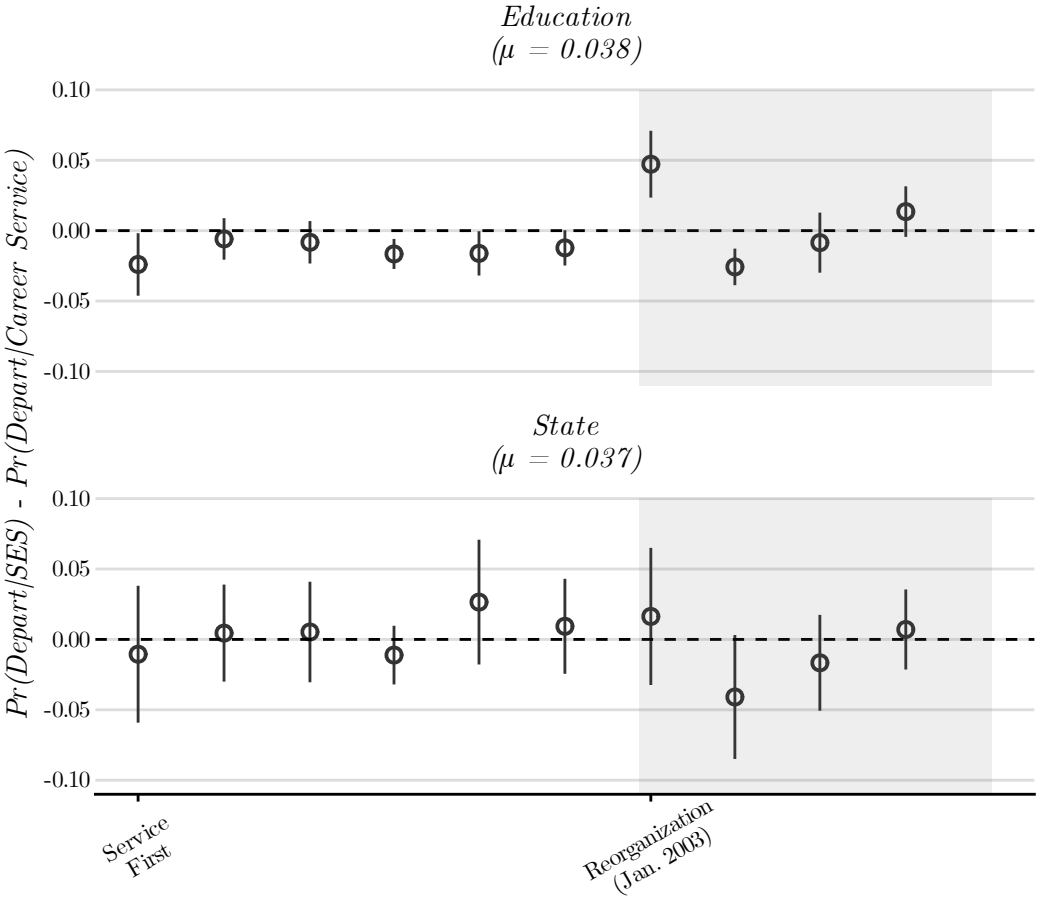


Figure 4 shows the results of the models as average marginal effects with associated 95% confidence in-

tervals.[16] The top (bottom) panel shows the difference in the predicted probability of departing by quarter for SES employees in the Department of Education (State), relative to Career Service employees in the Department of Education (State). The gray shading indicates the onset of the cabinet reorganization in January 2003. There is little difference across both panels in the predicted probability of departing in the quarters leading up to reorganization. At-will SES employees in the Departments of Education and State are equally likely to depart as their coworkers in the Career Service. That changes in the Department of Education in the first quarter following Bush officially gaining greater control of the agency. In that quarter, SES employees in the Department of Education were, on average, four percentage points more likely to depart the workforce than Career Service employees in the agency. This is a substantively large spike in employee turnover. The mean quarterly departure rate for SES and Career Service employees in the Department of Education was 3.8% for the study period, meaning that turnover increased by 124% in the first quarter following reorganization, relative to the baseline. Notably, the bottom panel demonstrates that there is no similar change in departures among at-will employees in the Department of State after Bush gained control of that agency, underscoring that the Department of Education's contentious relationship with the governor drove the spike in departures.

The magnitude and statistical significance of the increase in at-will departures in the Department of Education holds up to alternative modeling strategies. Figure F.2 shows that departures among SES employees in the Department of Education also increase following reorganization relative to other SES employees in the rest of the workforce. In subsequent quarters, the probability of departing decreases—possibly due to a need to retain existing staff after the prior terminations– and then remains slightly elevated. No increase in the probability of departing occurs among SES employees in the Department of State in January 2003. Finally, neither set of tests in Figures 4 or F.2 directly test whether at-will departures were more common in the Department of Education, relative to the Department of State. Figure F.1, therefore, uses a separate model to plot the quarterly difference between the SES and Career Service departure probability gaps across the Departments of Education and State. In January 2003, the difference between the two

[16] Table F.1 shows the coefficients on the control variables in the models used to estimate the average marginal effects.

differences widens, underscoring that at-will departures from the Department of Education were more common immediately following reorganization. Although the estimate does not reach standard levels of statistical significance ($p = 0.07$), calculating a pooled estimate using all post-reorganization quarters suggests that the lack of conventional statistical significance is an artifcat of low power. Additional details about this test can be found in Section F of the SI.

The personnel data is unable to parse whether the spike in departures resulted from employees being fired or resigning. It could be the case, for instance, that numerous at-will SES employees decided to resign in January 2003 upon the reorganization. However, an interview with a former Department of Education SES employee who lost their job in January 2003 indicates that the separations were the result of involuntary terminations. The employee describes being one of about "75 people" who were "fired" from the department on the same day. When the employee arrived to work on the day they were terminated, the employee was unable to access the building or their computer. "Within you know like 15 or 20 minutes I get called in to this office with these higher-ups and they say to me you can either quit or you'll [sic] you're fired and . . . so I said to these guys I said why would I quit . . . you can fire me and so they fire me and I walked out and that was it." The employee's termination, notably, was swift and came as a surprise. Without civil service protections in place, agency heads were able to dismiss the employee quickly without having to contend with due process procedures or appeals.

Discussion & Conclusion

A considerable literature has examined the consequences of implementing merit-based civil service protections (e.g. Carpenter 2001; Skowronek 1982; Folke, Hirano, and Snyder 2011; Aneja and Xu 2024; Moreira and Pérez 2021). Much less work has focused on the more recent rollbacks of protections for public sector employees. My results suggest that we cannot understand the latter by simply "reversing" the effects of the initial implementation of civil service protections. The massive changes to administrative states that have occurred since, and in part due to, the adoption of civil service protections means that rolling back civil service protections does not simply send personnel management back to the days of spoils and high

turnover. The importance of bureaucratic expertise to implementing policy and maintaining the delivery of government services means that executives will be hesitant to remove employees on a wide scale, even after their formal protections have been rolled back.

Yet, the importance of policy to modern executives also means that they will try to control opposing agencies implementing misaligned policy. As demonstrated by the case of the Florida Department of Education, without protections in place, policy conflict can lead to terminations of opposing bureaucrats. After Bush gained greater control of the agency, he was able to efficiently remove influential employees. Jeb Bush is far from the first executive to try and push out opposing government employees. But without protections in place, he was able to do it quickly via a process that more closely resembled the dismissal of political appointees than the protracted removal of civil servants.

These results have implications far beyond Florida in the early 2000s. The weakening of civil service protections in the states has received heightened attention in recent years as President Trump has tried multiple times to weaken protections for federal workers. Proponents of these reforms have made the case that state-level reforms show that making it easier to fire federal employees will improve performance without increasing politicization (Glock and Mukherjee 2025). My findings suggest greater caution is warranted. Unlike the contemporary federal Executive Branch, the Republican-controlled states where civil service protections have been weakened likely lack widespread conflict between bureaucrats and governors—even though there are large swaths of misaligned Democratic public employees serving in many Republican state bureaucracies (Goehring 2025). Consistent one-party rule, a lack of conflict over agency tasks, bureaucrats' self-selection into the workforce, and executives possessing other tools for controlling agencies means that at-will employment likely rarely needs to be employed to remove problematic bureaucrats. Governors and legislators can pass reforms to roll back protections—and score political points in the process by showing the public they are attempting to make government work better—but cases of actual conflict between governors and bureaucrats, with the resulting terminations of at-will employees, will likely be few and far between.

As a result, accurately mapping the consequences of state-level rollbacks to the federal level requires moving past workforce-level analyses to specific cases where skepticism and antagonism between the gov-

ernor and bureaucrats is high. This is apparent in the case of the Florida Department of Education, where Bush's conflict with state bureaucrats led to a purge of opposing employees. This finding, not the overall lack of heightened turnover in July 2001, is likely the more accurate takeaway for understanding how civil service rollbacks would play out at the federal level. Weakening federal civil service protections will not lead to a return to a spoils system, but it will increase the president's control over an increasingly powerful and polarizing administrative state.

Other work should build on some of the limitations in this study. While I focus on the effect of civil service rollbacks on terminations, leaving the public sector is a rare event. There are other, less extreme, ways that rolling back civil service protections can influence bureaucrats. For example, employees may adjust their behavior following the rollback of civil service protections to better align with principals' expectations. Executives may also attempt to marginalize employees without resorting to removing them from their jobs. Likewise, much of the formal literature on civil service protections emphasize their effects on hiring patterns. Longitudinal data on who is applying and entering into state employment, for instance, would provide a window into whether reducing public sector employees' insulation from removal affects the willingness of more motivated or qualified individuals from entering the workforce.

Another important avenue for future research is the effects of civil service rollbacks on compensation. Proponents of rollbacks often contend that relaxing civil service protections allows supervisors to more easily compensate highly performing employees. In the SI in Figures E.2 and E.3 I demonstrate, descriptively, that while mean salaries rose in tandem for treated and control positions after Service First, the dispersion of salaries among positions more affected by rollbacks increases, potentially indicating greater discretion in compensation for at-will workers.

Future studies should also mine additional cases of civil service rollbacks from other states and longer time periods. State governments' unique institutional arrangements (Krause and Woods 2014; Seifter 2017, 2018) and the ubiquity of one-party rule are interesting, critical features of state politics that likely also factor into how rollbacks influence public management. Finally, additional research is urgently needed on the impacts of weakened civil service protections on public policy and personnel quality. Matching rollbacks to measures of agency or individual valence is a difficult but crucial step in assessing how best to

manage bureaucracies.

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Supplementary Information

Bureaucratic Turnover After Civil Service Rollbacks

Benjamin Goehring

A Service First **SI-1**

B Measuring Employees' Period of Departure **SI-2**

C Voter Records Merge **SI-4**

D Alternative Specifications of `PanelMatch` Models **SI-7**

E Additional `PanelMatch` Information **SI-11**

F Alternative Specifications of Dept. of Education Analysis **SI-20**

A Service First

Figure A.1 – Reclassification Into SES More Likely For Higher Earners and More Experienced Employees Working In/Around Tallahassee. Shows the predicted probability of an employee being reclassified from the Career Service into the SES by annual salary, years of experience, and whether they work in or around Tallahassee. Predicted probabilities calculated from a logit model with controls for race, sex, years of experience, agency, and location. Predicted probabilities calculated using observed values via the `marginaleffects` R package.

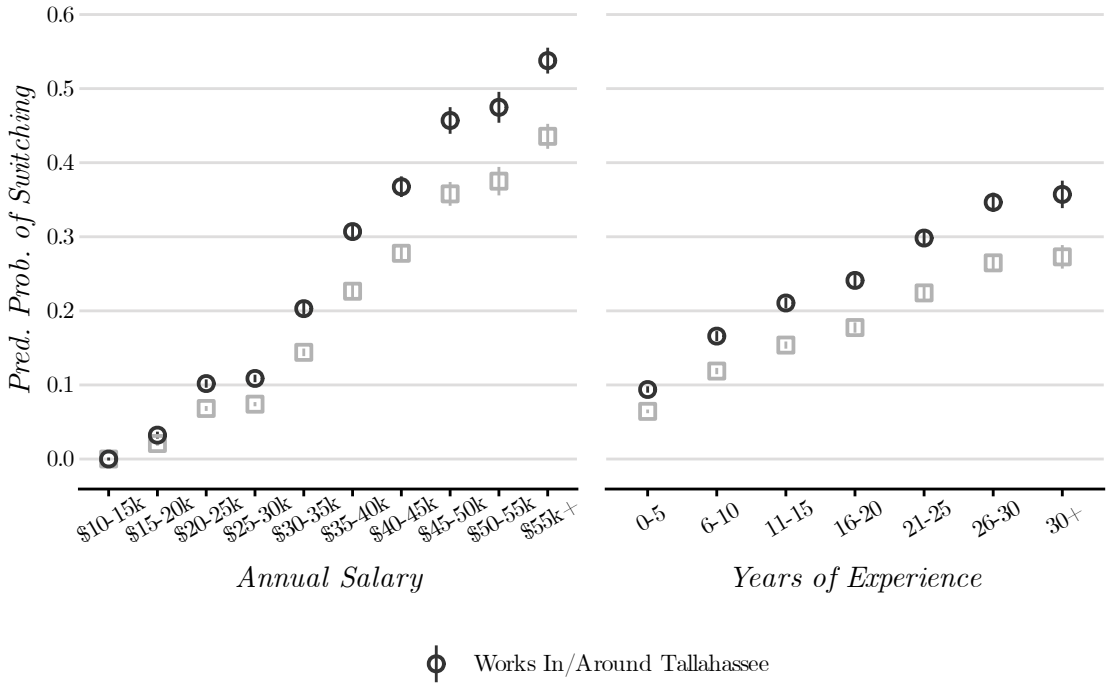


Table A.1 – Calculated vs. Reported Number of Employees, by Civil Service Status
Shows the number of employees, by civil service status as reported in Florida's annual workforce reports (as of December 31st) and the number calculated in the personnel file as of January 1st of the following year (i.e., one day difference).

Civil Service Status	Date	Annual Report	Calculated
Career Service	Jan-2000	110,952	102,988
Career Service	Jan-2001	109,389	104,682
Career Service	Jan-2002	90,519	86,616
Career Service	Jan-2003	88,681	85,541
Career Service	Jan-2004	87,466	84,387
SES	Jan-2000	3,440	3,345
SES	Jan-2001	3,696	3,472
SES	Jan-2002	19,454	18,411
SES	Jan-2003	19,478	18,602
SES	Jan-2004	18,925	18,020

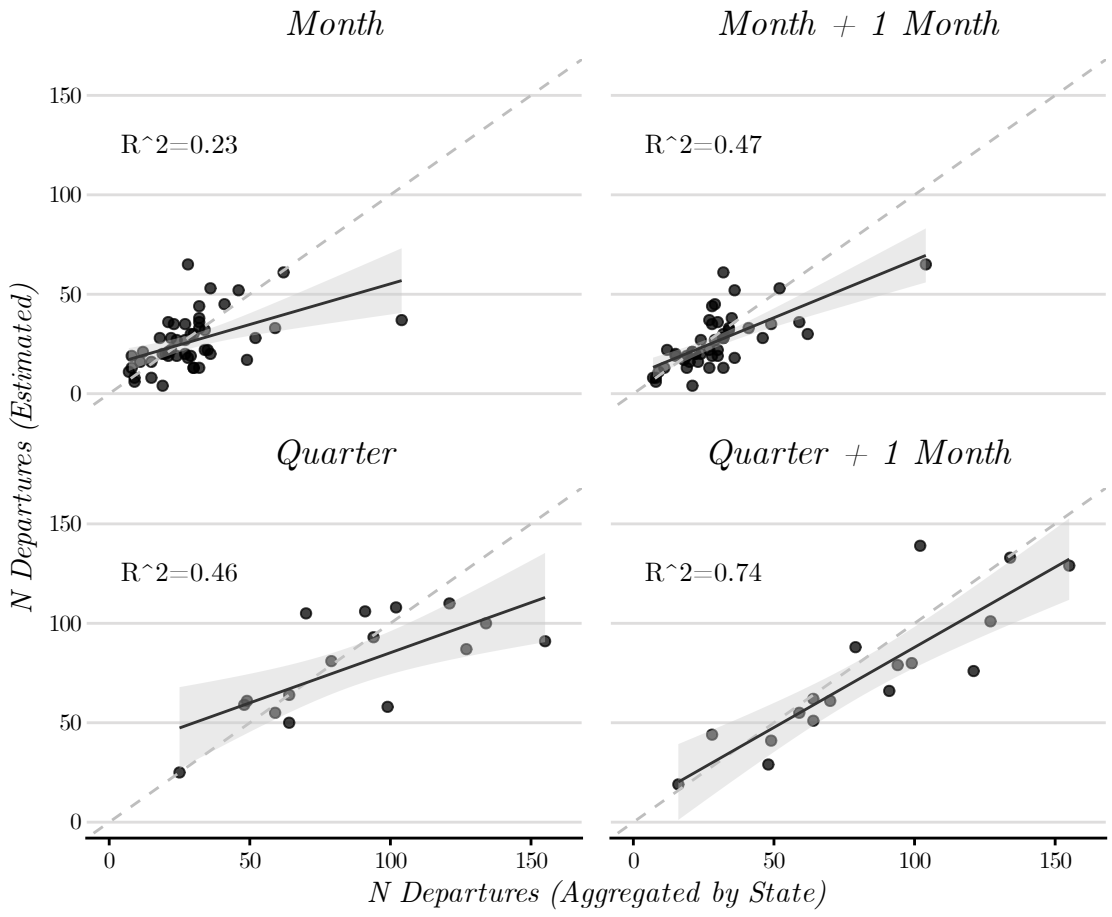
B Measuring Employees' Period of Departure

The Florida personnel data does not note an employee's date of departure. Instead, I measure departures as the last month an employee appears in the dataset. It is ambiguous in the data whether the last month an employee is in the data is the last month they were employed, or if they actually departed in the following month. In order to validate the measure, I requested and received aggregated data from the Florida Department of Education of the total number of voluntary and involuntary departures in a given month. The top-left panel of Figure B.1 shows the relationship between that monthly aggregated data and the number of employees whose last month in the data was the same month. The relationship between the two measures is weak. If the estimated departure month is lagged one month forward (i.e., if an employee's last month in the personnel data is January 2002, then they are listed as departing in February 2002), the relationship between the two datasets is more similar.

It is difficult to know why these differences arise between the personnel data from the Florida Department of Management Services and the aggregated monthly departure data from the Department of Education. One possibility is inconsistent definitions of when someone actually departs the state agency. For instance, if the personnel data is a snapshot from the end of the given month, then some employees might be departing on the last day of the month, while others might not leave until the following month. This could be inconsistently reported across agencies.

In order to address this issue, I take a two-pronged approach. First, given the improved fit of the top-right panel of Figure B.1 relative to the top-left panel, I lead the month of departure forward one month from the last observed date. In practice, this means that when an employee departs the dataset, I add an additional row that is identical except for increasing month by one. Furthermore, I measure departures at each quarter rather than monthly. The two plots in the second row of Figure B.1 show similar comparisons aggregated to the quarterly level. Leading the month of departure forward one month and then measuring departures quarterly (bottom-right plot), shows the highest level of agreement with the aggregated departure data from the Department of Education. Therefore, this approach is used in both the `PanelMatch` and individual-level Department of Education reorganization models.

Figure B.1 – Validating Employee Departure Measure with Department of Education Data. Each plot shows the number of employees estimated to have departed the Department of Education in a period (i.e., month or quarter) compared to the number who departed during that period according to separate aggregated data provided by the state Department of Education. The two plots on the right lead the estimated month of departure forward one month. The solid black line shows the fitted regression line and associated 95% confidence interval, while the dashed gray line shows the ideal one-to-one relationship.



C Voter Records Merge

I used the following algorithm to match employees in the personnel file to their corresponding voter records:

1. For each state employee, find all voters where the Jaro-Winkler string distance between both the first and last names is less than .025.[17]

2. Post-process the potential matches, removing any voters matched to a state employee who have:

   (a) A different, non-missing middle initial

   (b) A different race (unless the employee is only matched to one voter)

   (c) A different gender (unless the employee is only matched to one voter)

   (d) A date of birth that is more than 70 years from the last date I observe the state employee (unless the employee is only matched to one voter)

   (e) A date of birth that is more than 80 years from the last date I observe the state employee

   (f) A residential address that is not in the same county or an adjacent county as the state employee's county of employment

3. Since more than one voter can still be matched to a given state employee, calculate the mean probability that each employee is a registered Republican, Democrat, non-partisan, and member of another party. For instance, if an employee is matched to a Republican voter and Democratic voter, they would be assigned to be a Republican with a probability of 0.5, a Democrat with a probability of 0.5, non-partisan with a probability of 0, and of another party with a probability of 0. If an employee is matched to one voter or more than one voter who all share the same partisan affiliation, their partisanship is set to 1 for the given partisanship category.

   Overall, 57% of employees (and 59% of employee-month observations) were matched to at least one voter, which aligns with the 66% overall citizen voter registration rate in Florida in November 2002 (U.S. Census Bureau 2004). Of those matched employees, nearly all (95%) are matched to one and only one voter.

   Figure C.1 shows that, as expected, match rates increase over our study period as the personnel snapshots become closer in time to the date of the voter registration snapshot. Figure C.2 shows that Florida has a relatively small share of its population moving to a different state during our study period, tempering concerns about employees moving out of state.

[17] To speed up the merges, I blocked the employee and voter files on the concatenation of the first character of the first and last names.

Figure C.1 – Share of Employees Matched to At Least One Voter, by Month. Shows the share of employees matched to at least one voter by month.

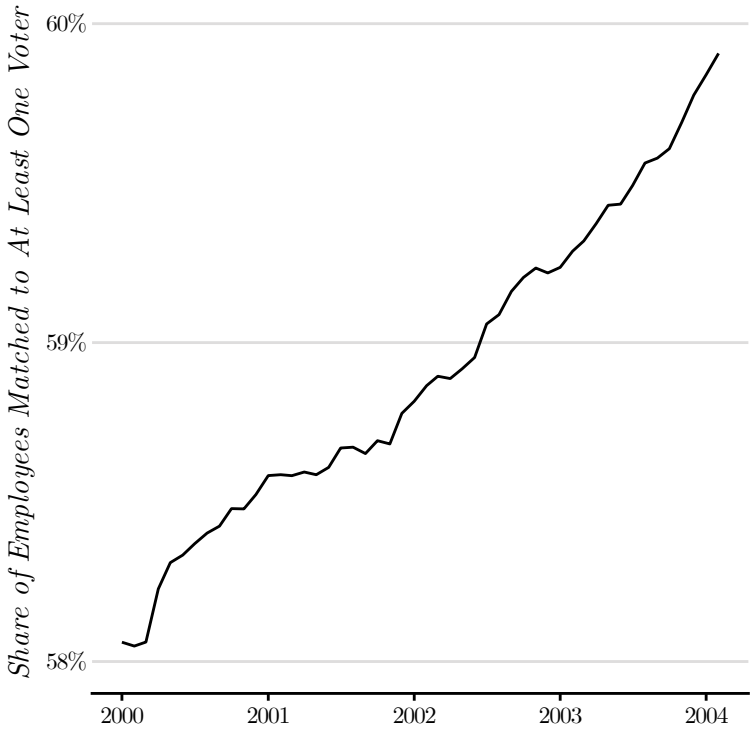
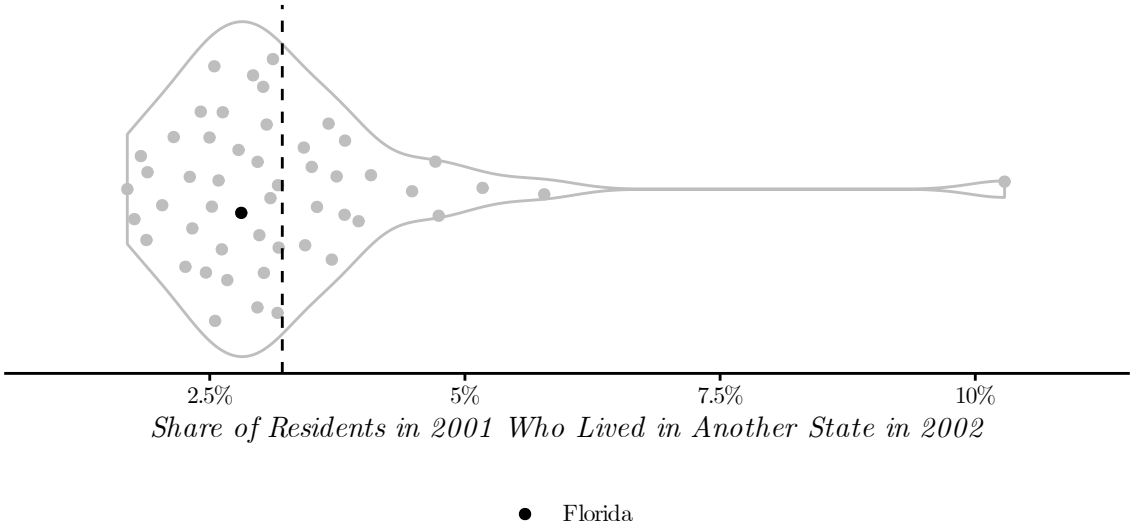


Table C.1 – Match Rates Among Employees Who Did and Did Not Depart, by County. Shows the number of employees who, respectively, did and did not depart the dataset in border and non-border counties as well as Leon county that were matched to at least one voter.

	N Employees		Share Matched		
County Type	Stayed	Departed	Stayed	Departed	Difference in Means
Border	14453	7684	0.54	0.49	0.05
Capital (Leon)	19846	9814	0.61	0.51	0.10
Non-border	69115	48424	0.61	0.54	0.06

Figure C.2 – Share of State Residents That Moved to a Different State in the U.S., 2001 to 2002. Shows the share of residents of a state in 2001 that moved to a different state in 2002. The dashed line shows the mean out-migration rate across all states and Washington DC. Results calculated using IRS migration data. The outlier is Washington DC.



D Alternative Specifications of `PanelMatch` Models

Figure D.1 – Service First Had Little Effect on Overall Turnover. Each facet shows point estimates and 95% confidence intervals of the effect of Service First on the share of employees who depart from a position in a given quarter. The facets vary in the operationalization of the treatment. For instance, the top-left facet defines a position to be treated if 95% or more of the employees in the position were actually switched into the SES due to Service First. Likewise, the control group includes all positions where fewer than 5% of the employees were switched. μ shows the respective baseline mean departure rates.

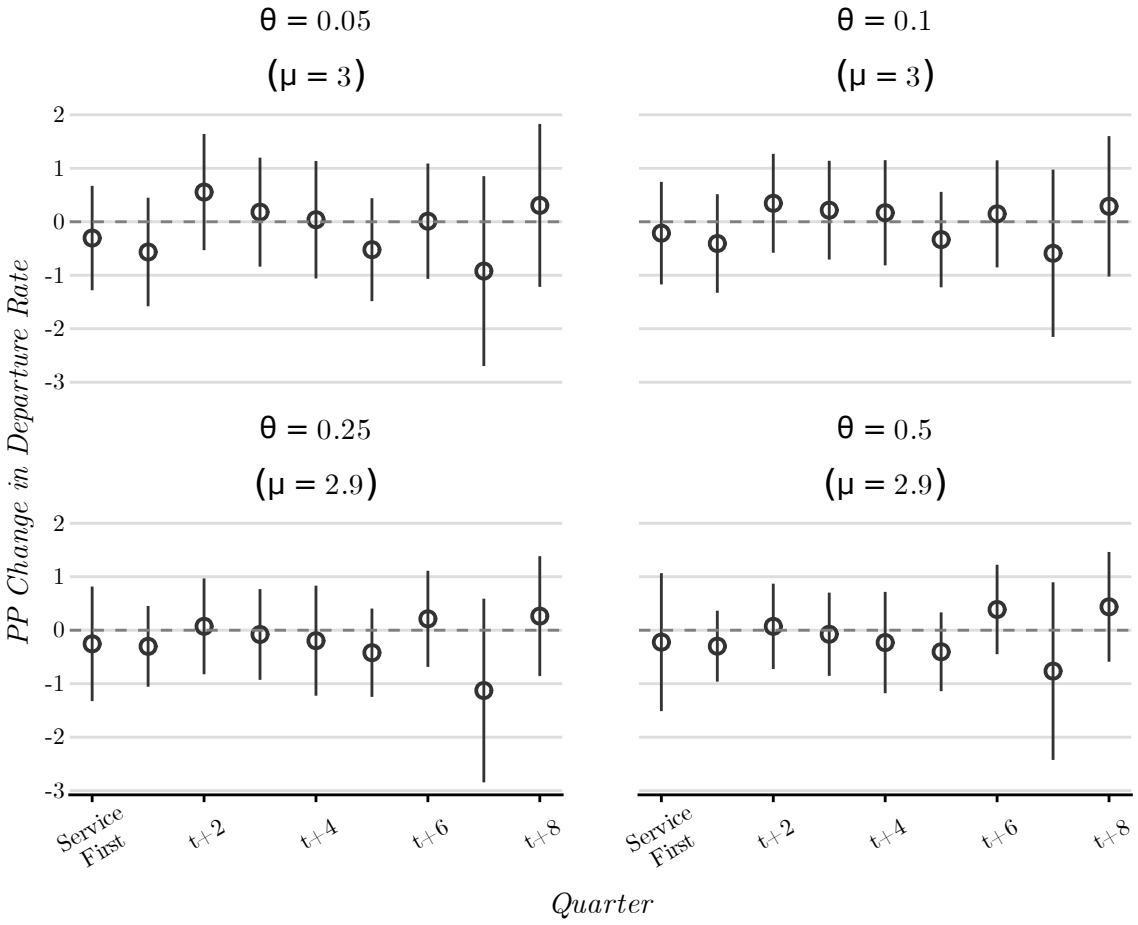


Figure D.2 – Little Evidence of Increased Departures in More Democratic Positions, Using Alternative Treatment Definitions. Each facet shows point estimates and 95% confidence intervals of the effect of Service First on the share of employees who depart from a position in a given quarter, by the partisan composition of the position. Darker circles (Lighter squares) show the effect for positions where the share of democrats exceeds (is less than) the median across the study period. The facets vary in the operationalization of the treatment. For instance, the top-left facet defines a position to be treated if 95% or more of the employees in the position were actually switched into the SES due to Service First. Likewise, the control group includes all positions where fewer than 5% of the employees were switched. μ shows the respective baseline mean departure rates.

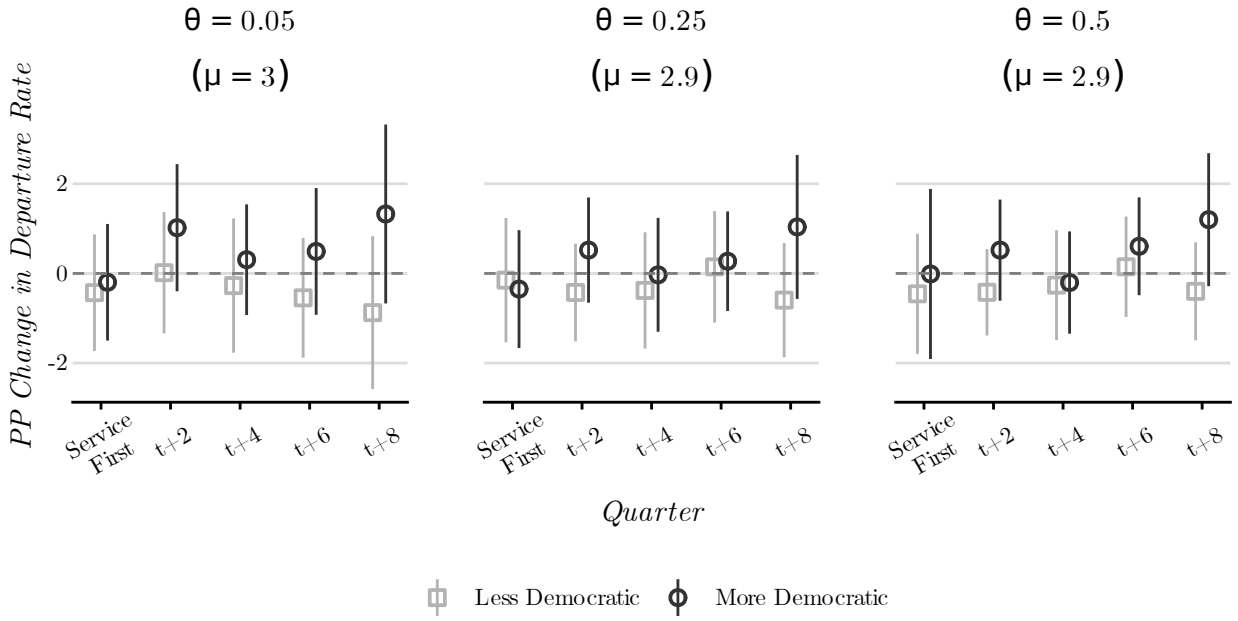


Figure D.3 – Little Evidence of Increased Departures in More Democratic Positions, Using Alternative Definition of Moderator Variable. Each facet shows point estimates and 95% confidence intervals of the effect of Service First on the share of employees who depart from a position in a given quarter, by the partisan composition of the position. Darker circles (Lighter squares) show the effect for positions where the share of democrats exceeds (is less than) the third quartile across the study period. The facets vary in the operationalization of the treatment. For instance, the top-left facet defines a position to be treated if 95% or more of the employees in the position were actually switched into the SES due to Service First. Likewise, the control group includes all positions where fewer than 5% of the employees were switched. μ shows the respective baseline mean departure rates.

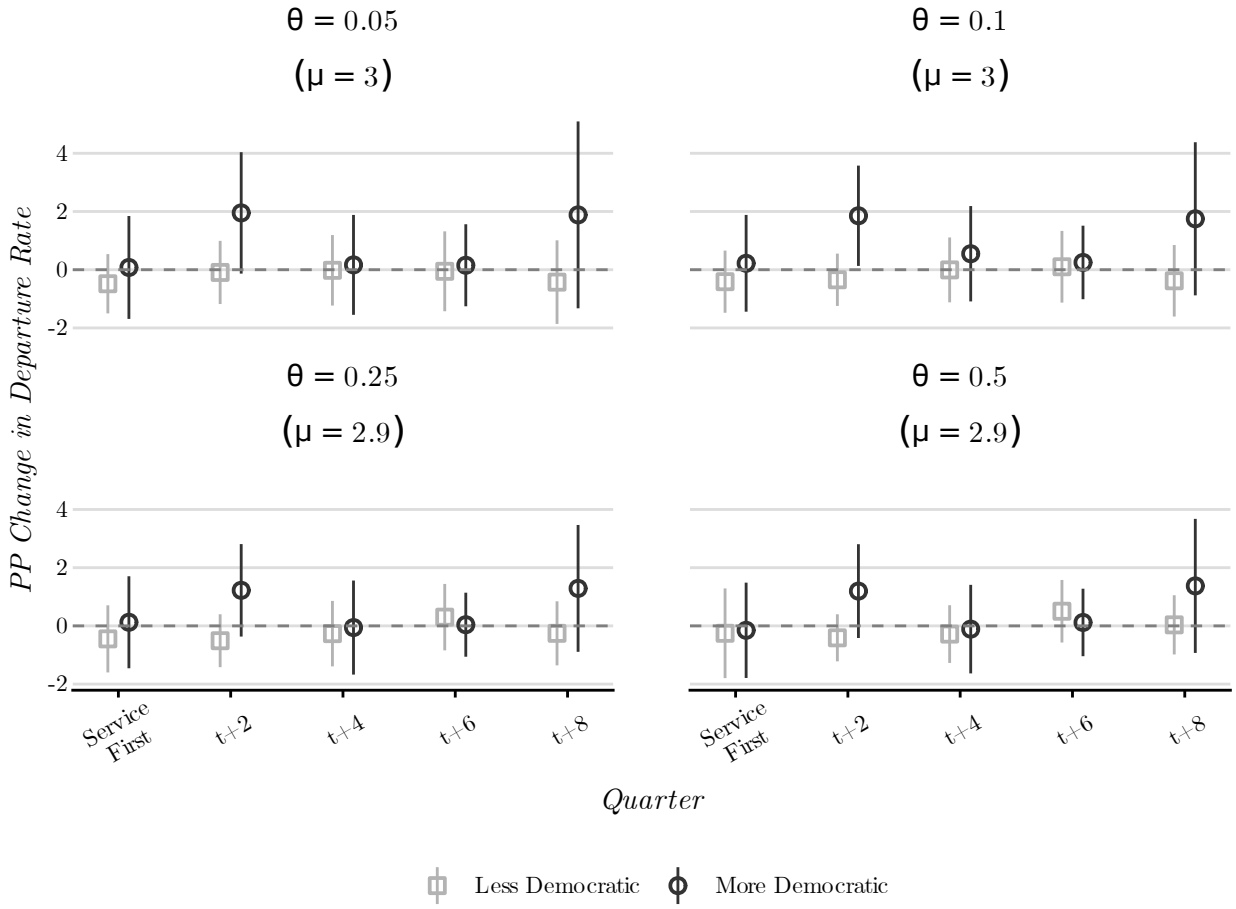


Figure D.4 – Little Evidence of Increased Departures in More Democratic Positions, Using Agency-Position as Unit of Analysis. Reruns results shown in Figures 3 and D.2 using the agency-position as the unit of analysis rather than the position. Models include agency-level fixed effects. μ shows the respective baseline mean departure rates.

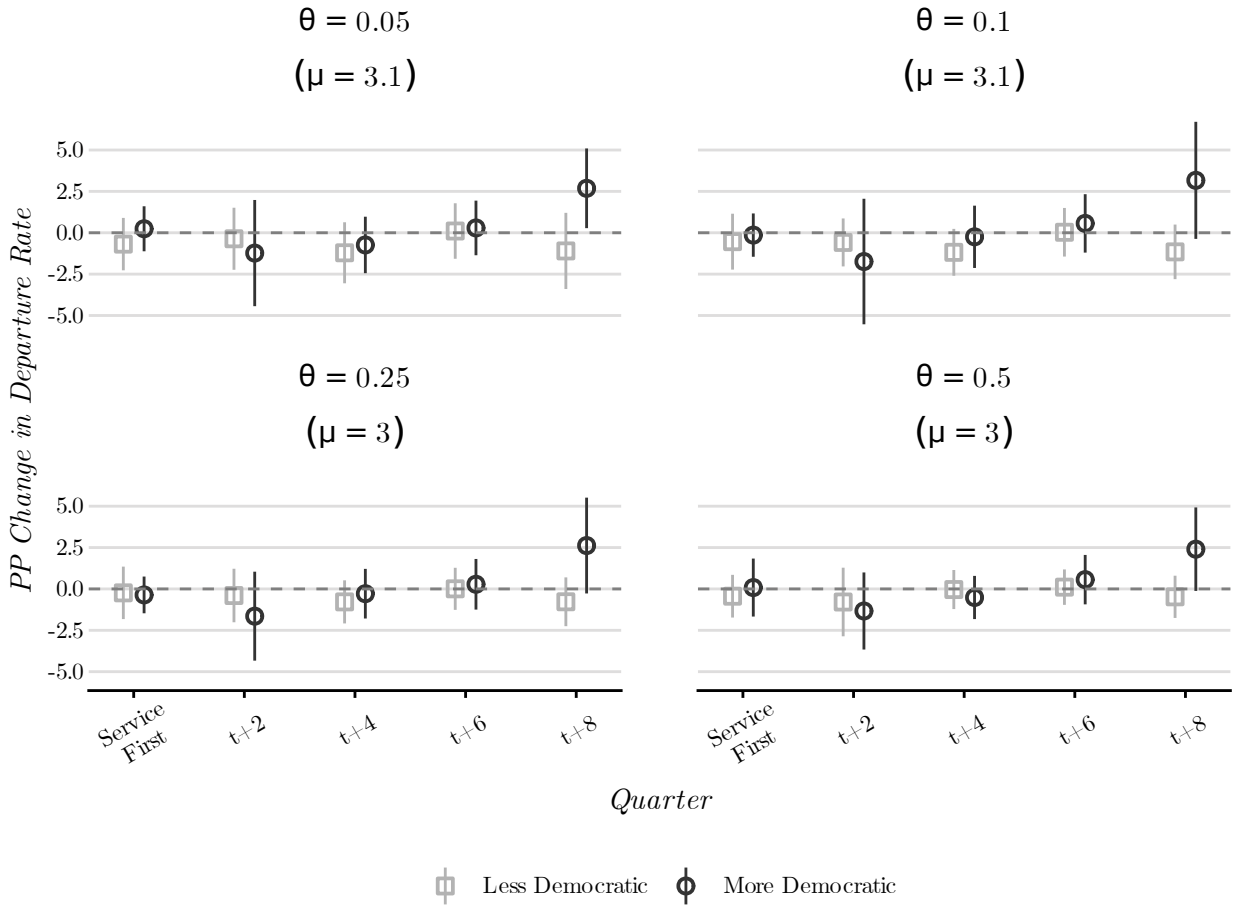
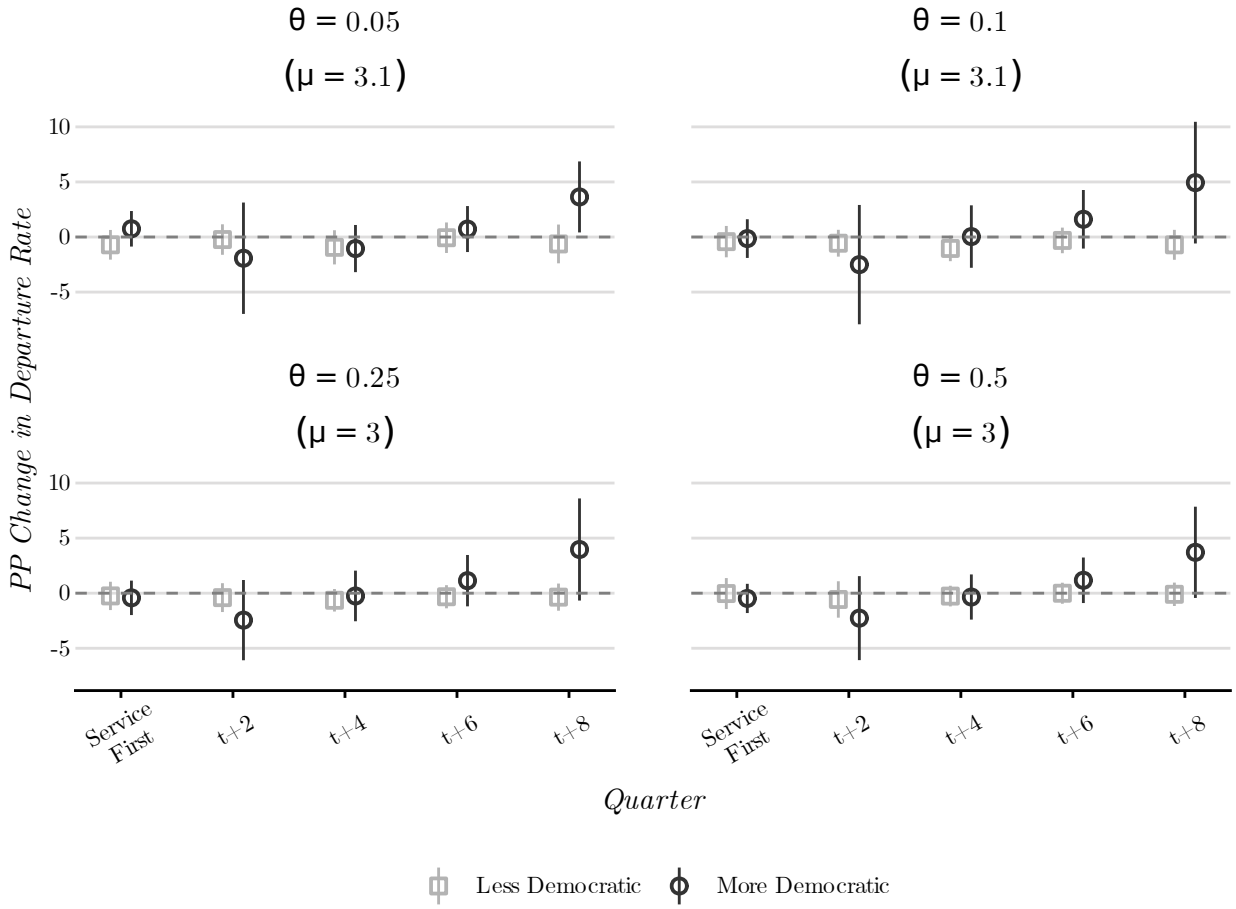


Figure D.5 – Little Evidence of Increased Departures in More Democratic Positions, Using Agency-Position as Unit of Analysis and Alternative Definition of Moderator Variable. Reruns results shown in Figure D.3 using the agency-position as the unit of analysis. μ shows the respective baseline mean departure rates.



E Additional `PanelMatch` Information

Table E.1 – Descriptive Statistics of Treatment (white) and Control (gray) Groups, April 2001 Shows, by treatment threshold, the number of positions, mean number of employees, and means of the outcome (share of employees that departed in the quarter) and covariates. The outcome and covariate means are weighted by the number of employees in a position. Values for the treated positions (where most employees lost civil service protections under Service First) are in white and the values for the control positions are in gray. Data is from April 2001.

N Positions	N Employees	Share Departed	Share White	Share Male	Share Capital	Mean Salary	Mean Years Exp.
$\theta = 0.05$							
321	236	0.03	0.60	0.45	0.13	$28,294	9.42
82	69	0.02	0.63	0.46	0.23	$38,334	16.05
$\theta = 0.1$							
346	228	0.03	0.60	0.46	0.14	$28,688	9.50
105	67	0.02	0.63	0.43	0.24	$37,378	15.52
$\theta = 0.25$							
392	218	0.03	0.61	0.44	0.17	$28,822	9.77
116	70	0.02	0.65	0.44	0.28	$37,889	15.34
$\theta = 0.5$							
419	213	0.03	0.61	0.43	0.18	$28,938	9.89
130	88	0.02	0.68	0.44	0.37	$39,127	14.95

Figure E.1 – Raw Quarterly Departure Rates by Treatment Status and Quarter. Shows the share of employees who departed the workforce in treated and control positions that were, respectively, more and less affected by Service First. A position is deemed treated (control) if the share of employees in the position switched into the SES in July 2001 is greater than (less than) or equal to 0.9 (0.1).

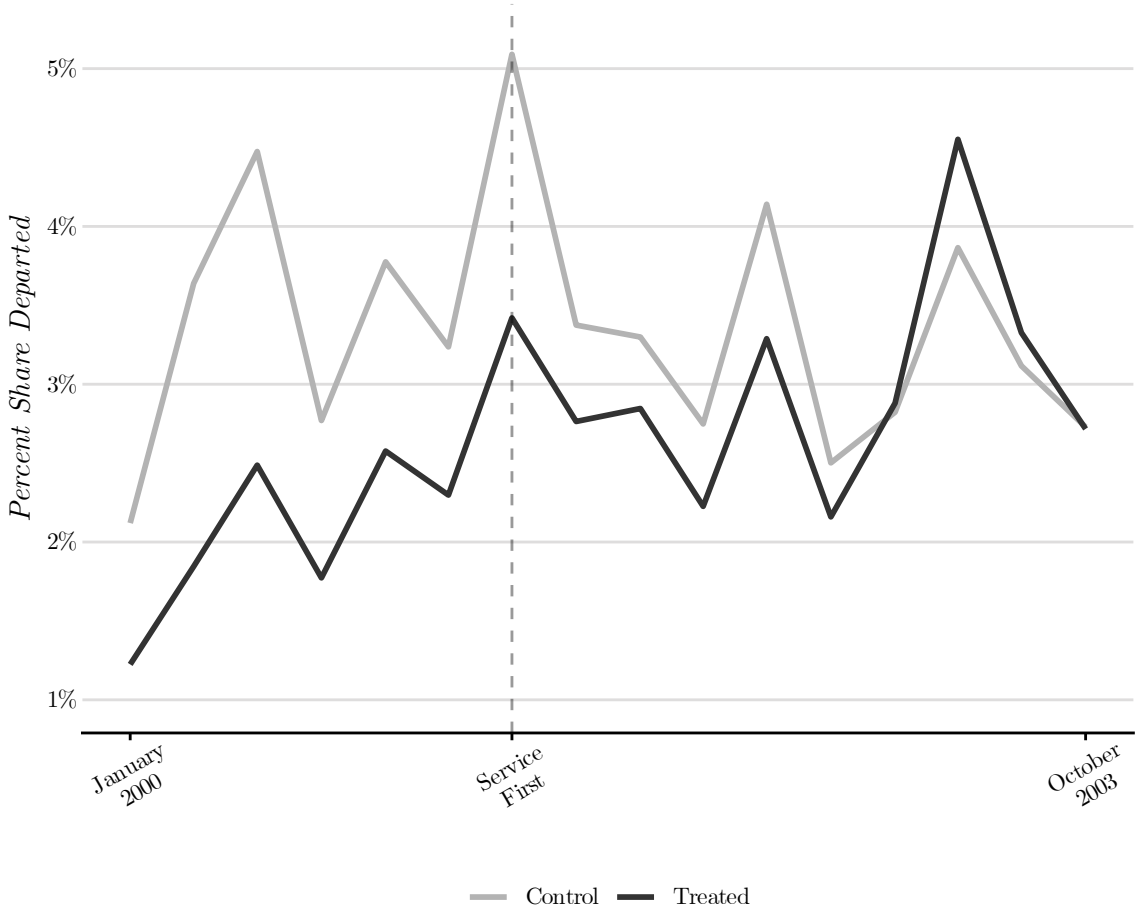


Figure E.2 – Mean Salary by Treatment Status and Quarter. The top panel shows the mean annual salary (in thousands of dollars) of employees in treated and control positions that were, respectively, more and less affected by Service First. The bottom panel indexes salary to the group's mean salary in April 2001. A position is deemed treated (control) if the share of employees in the position switched into the SES in July 2001 is greater than (less than) or equal to 0.9 (0.1).

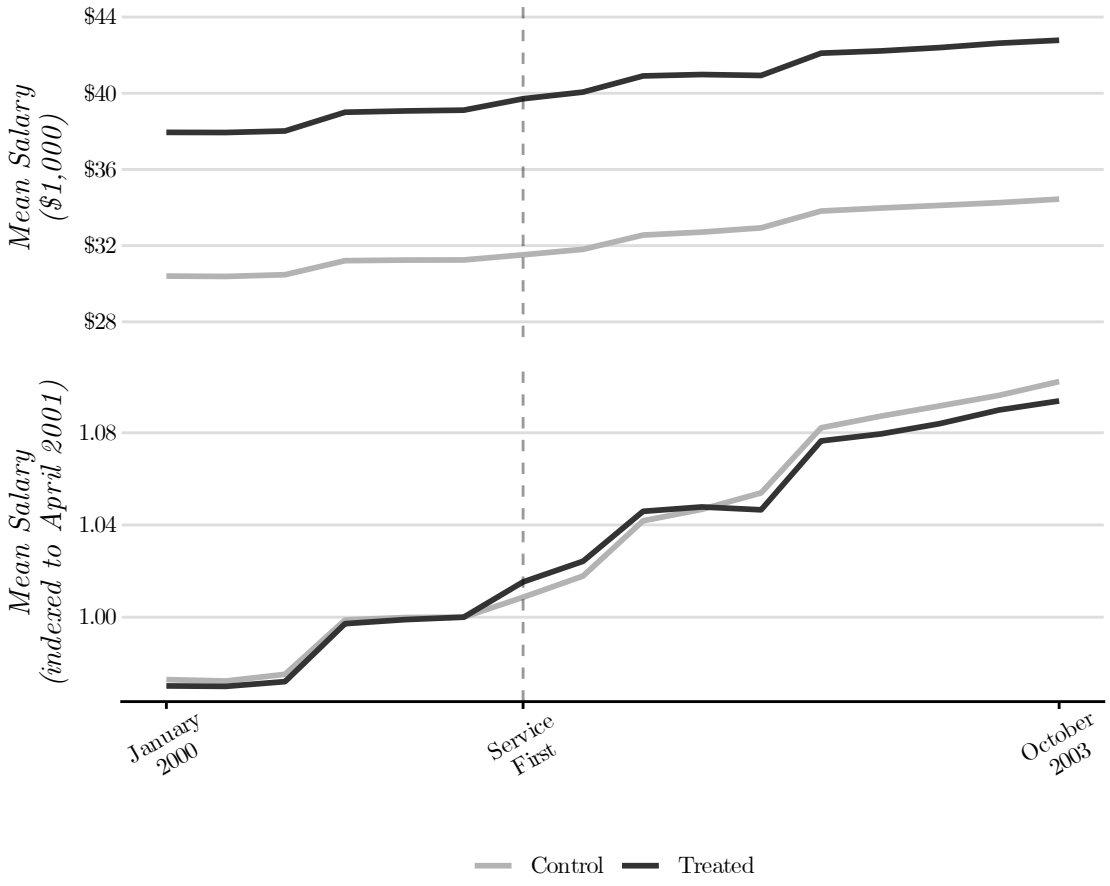


Figure E.3 – Standard Deviation of Salary by Treatment Status and Quarter. The top panel shows the standard deviation of annual salary (in thousands of dollars) of employees in treated and control positions that were, respectively, more and less affected by Service First. The bottom panel indexes the quarterly standard deviation to the group's value in April 2001. A position is deemed treated (control) if the share of employees in the position switched into the SES in July 2001 is greater than (less than) or equal to 0.9 (0.1). One position is excluded due to extreme values.

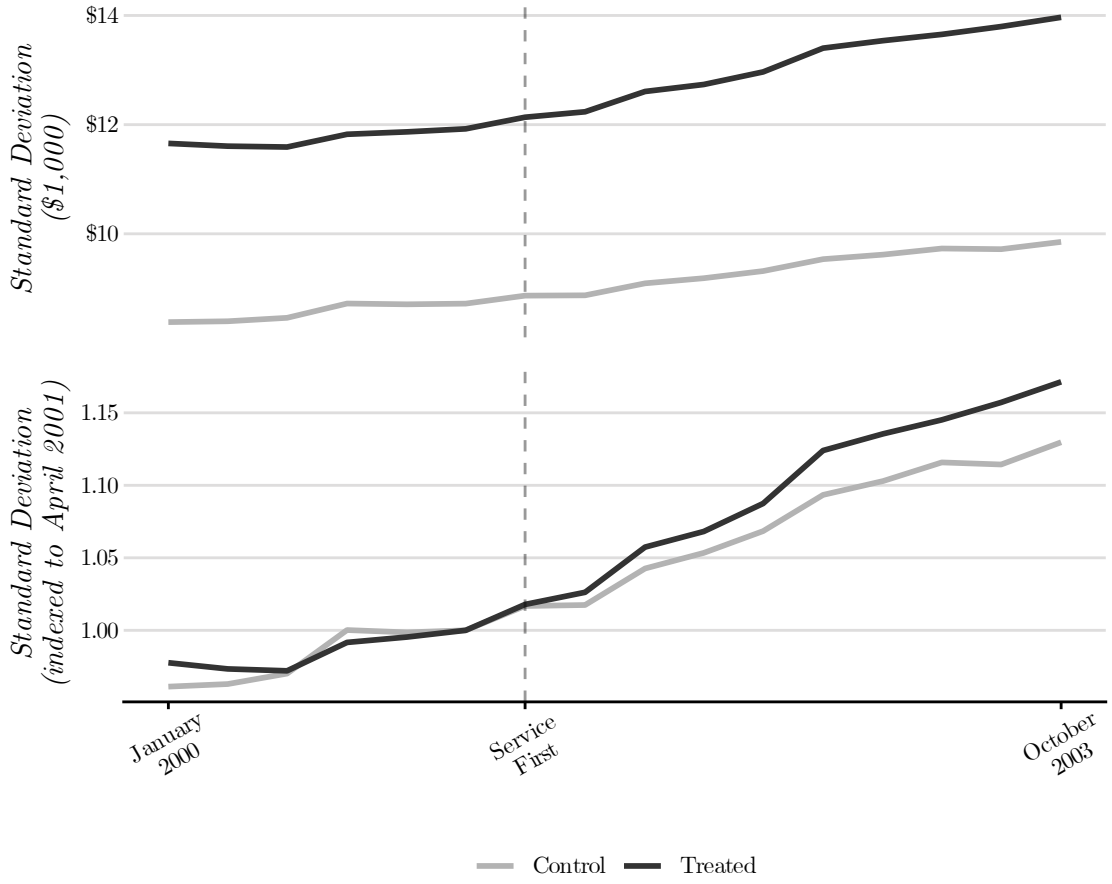


Figure E.4 – Ten Largest Agencies in `PanelMatch` Analysis Dataset, by Treatment Status. The top (bottom) panel shows the ten agencies in the treated (control) group with the most employees. The "Other" category includes all other agencies. Employees are deemed to be in the treatment (control) group if the share of all employees in their position switched into the SES in July 2001 is greater than (less than) or equal to 0.9 (0.1).

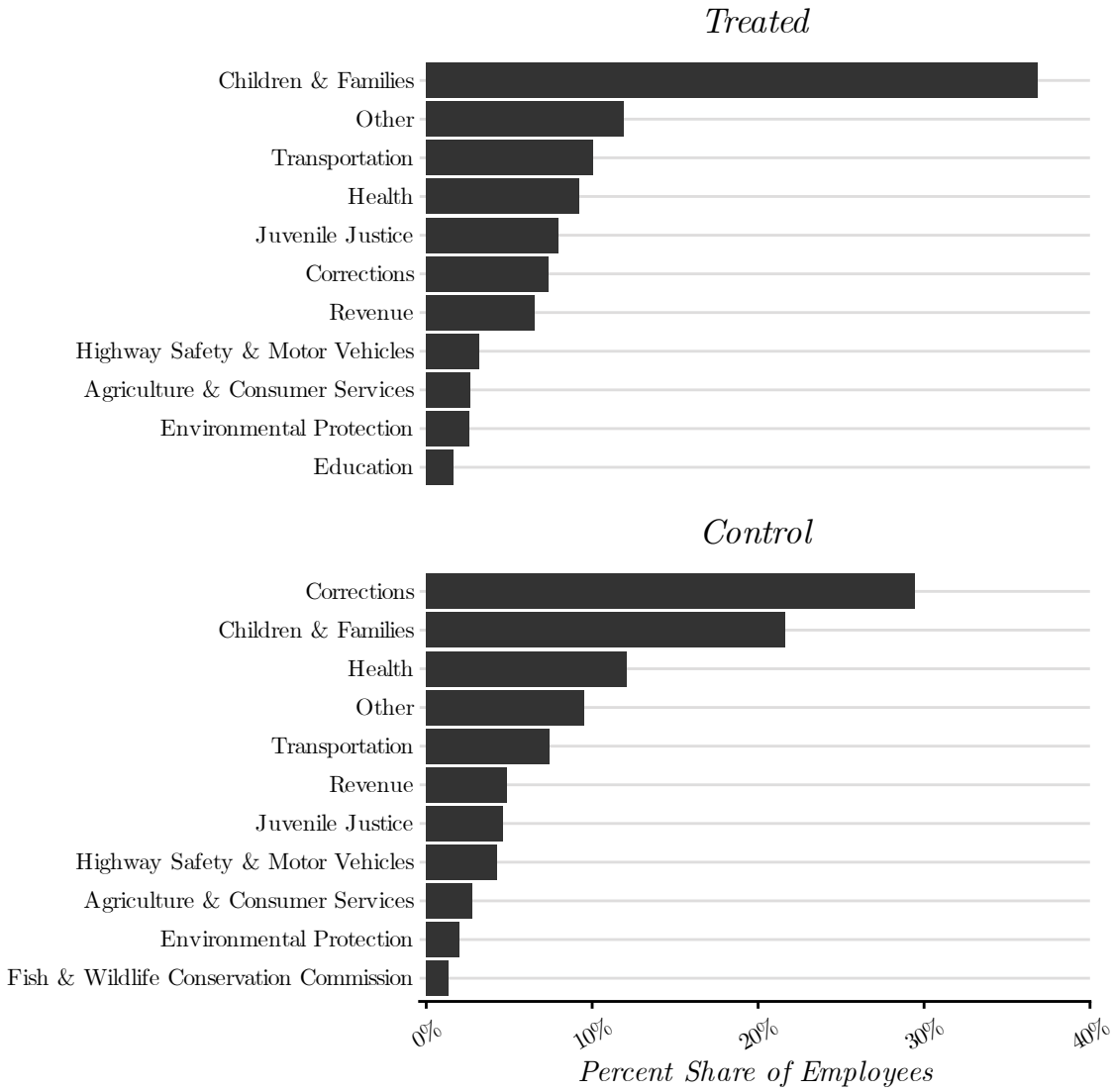


Figure E.5 – Covariate Balance, by Treatment Definition. Shows the covariate balance in pre-treatment quarters between treated and control positions, where the unit of analysis is the position. Covariate balancing is conducted using Covariate Balance Propensity Score weighting.

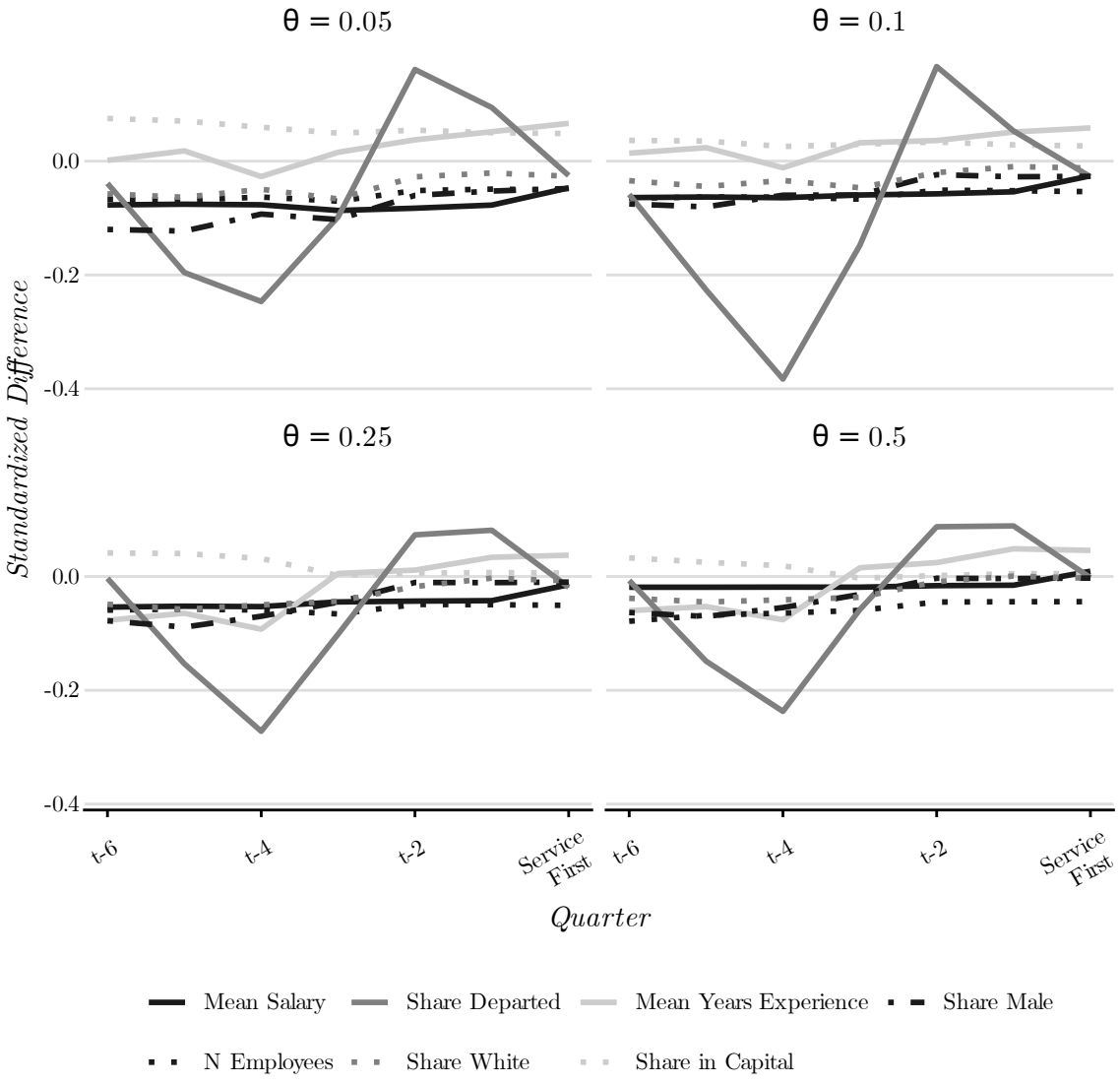


Figure E.6 – Number of Employees in Positions. Shows the number of employees in each position over time. Note that no new employees enter the positions post-treatment.

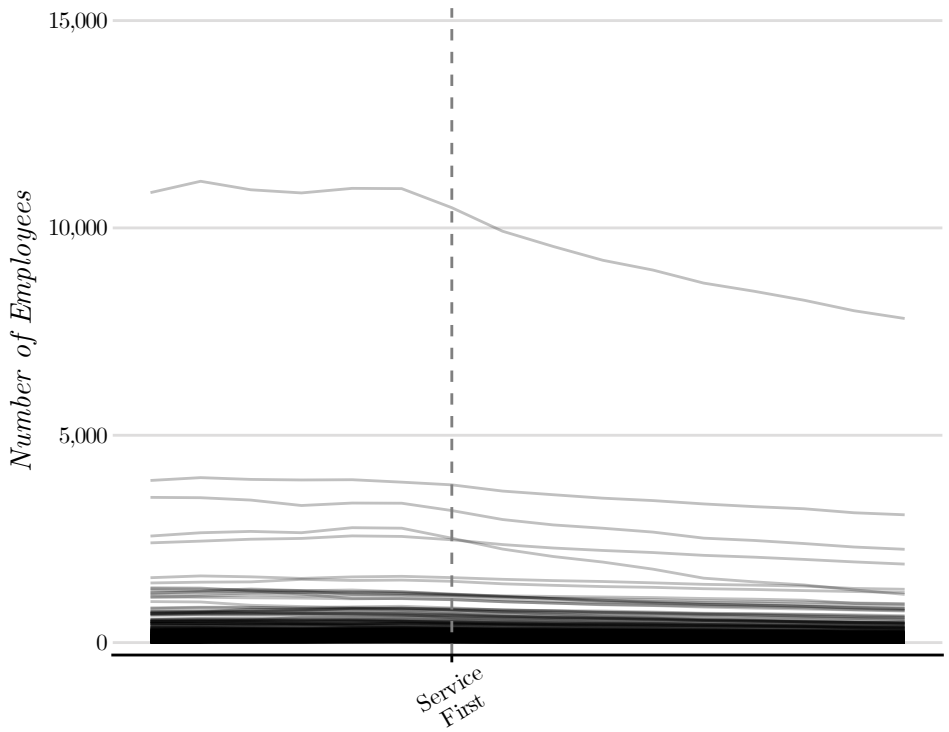
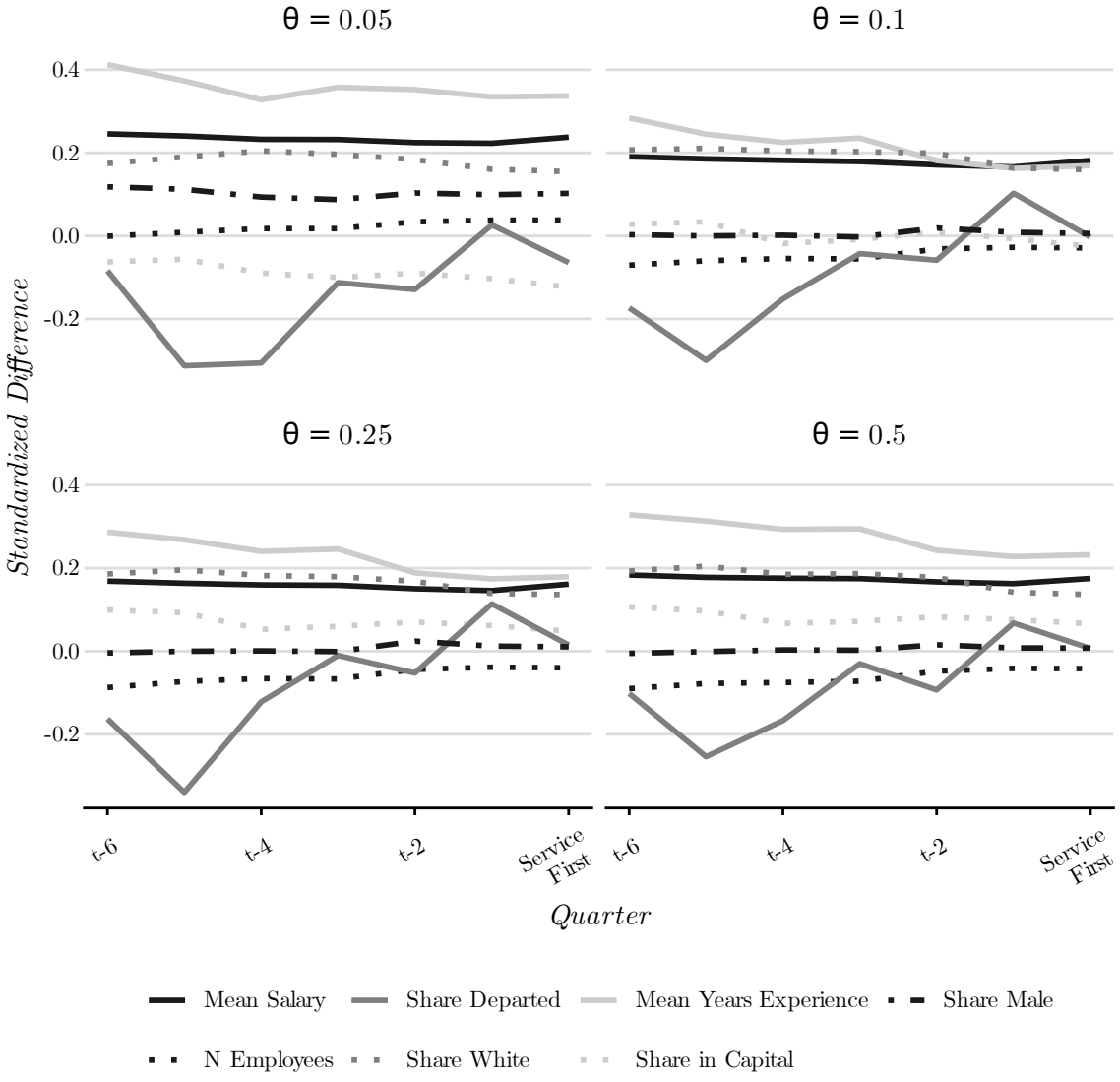


Figure E.7 – Control and Treatment Positions Less Well-Balanced with Agency-Position as Unit of Analysis. Shows the pre-treatment balance of covariates and outcome variable using agency-position as the unit of analysis. Figure D.4 shows the corresponding results.



F Alternative Specifications of Dept. of Education Analysis

Figures 4 and F.2 show that departures among at-will employees in the Department of Education significantly increase in the quarter following reorganization. In contrast, departures do not increase among at-will employees in the Department of State in January 2003, relative to either other SES employees in the agency or SES employees throughout the rest of the Florida workforce. Both sets of tests examine whether departures increase in the respective agency relative to other SES employees. They do not test whether departures among at-will employees increased more in the Department of Education than the Department of State following the January 2003 reorganization.

I test for this using a triple interaction. Specifically, I regress whether an employee departed in a given quarter against the interaction of a quarterly time fixed effect, whether an employee works in the SES or Career Service, and a categorical indicator for whether they are employed in the Department of Education, Department of State, or another agency. The logit model includes the same controls as in the model described in the text. I then use this model to estimate predicted probabilities. Specifically, I calculate, using standard errors clustered by employee, whether the difference in predicted probability of departing among SES and Career Service employees is wider in the Department of Education than the Department of State. The difference-in-difference estimates are calculated for each quarter.

Figure F.1 shows the results with 95% confidence intervals. The results are in line with the results in Figures 4 and F.2. Before Jeb Bush gained greater control of the two agencies in January 2003, there is little difference across the agencies in departures among at-will employees. Beginning in January 2003, departures among at-will SES employees in the Department of Education increase relative to departures among Career Service employees in the Department of Education by a greater amount than the associated difference in the Department of State. The increase in January 2003 does not reach standard levels of statistical significance ($p = 0.07$), but this is likely an artifact of low power. Calculating the same difference-in-differences but pooling together data from all post-reorganization quarters results in a smaller magnitude but statistically significant effect ($\beta = 0.027$, $p = 0.02$).

Table F.1 – Control Variables for Departments of Education and State Analysis. Shows the time-invariant control variables used in the logit models that underlie Figures 4 and F.2. Quarterly fixed effects, main treatment effects (i.e., member of SES in models 1 and 2 and member of respective agency in models 3 and 4), and the interactions between the time fixed effects and the treatment variables are omitted. Coefficients are on the log-odds scale and standard errors are in parentheses.

	Within-Agency		Within-SES	
	Education	State	Education	State
White	0.144	0.200	-0.152***	-0.153***
	(0.083)	(0.220)	(0.030)	(0.030)
Female	0.056	0.344	0.142***	0.156***
	(0.087)	(0.191)	(0.029)	(0.029)
Unemployment Rate	-0.119	0.945**	0.005	0.010
	(0.089)	(0.355)	(0.020)	(0.020)
Works in Capital	-0.011	-0.690	-0.241***	-0.249***
	(0.124)	(0.467)	(0.036)	(0.036)
Annual Salary ($10k)	0.044	0.004	-0.026**	-0.027**
	(0.041)	(0.104)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Num.Obs.	20362	4353	179874	175205
Years of Experience FE	✓	✓	✓	✓

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Figure F.1 – The Gap in the Probability of Departing Between Employees in SES vs. Career Service Is Higher in the Department of Education Following Reorganization. Displays how the SES versus Career Service departure probability gap changes over time in the Department of Education relative to the Department of State. Differences in predicted probabilities estimated from a logistic regression with a triple interaction between whether an employee is in the at-will SES, a quarterly time fixed effect, and a categorical indicator for whether an employee is the Department of Education, Department of State, or another agency. Standard errors are clustered by employee and 95% confidence intervals shown alongside point estimates.

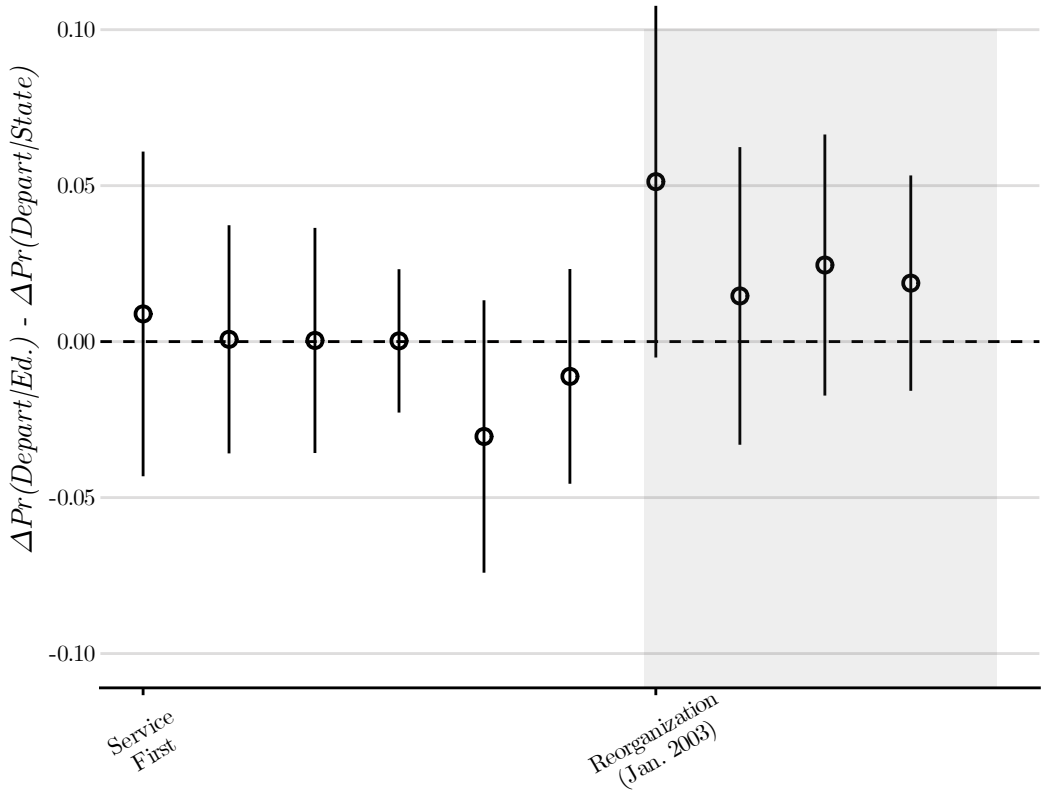


Figure F.2 – At-Will Employees in Department of Education More Likely to Depart in Quarter After Reorganization (Relative to Other SES Employees). Shows the difference in the predicted probability of departing the workforce for employees in the SES in, respectively, the Departments of Education and State, relative to SES employees in the rest of the Florida workforce. Bars denote 95% confidence intervals and standard errors are clustered by employee. Predicted probabilities calculated using observed values via the `marginaleffects R` package. Shading indicates the onset of the cabinet reorganization that gave Governor Jeb Bush greater control of the agency. μ shows the respective baseline mean departure rates.

